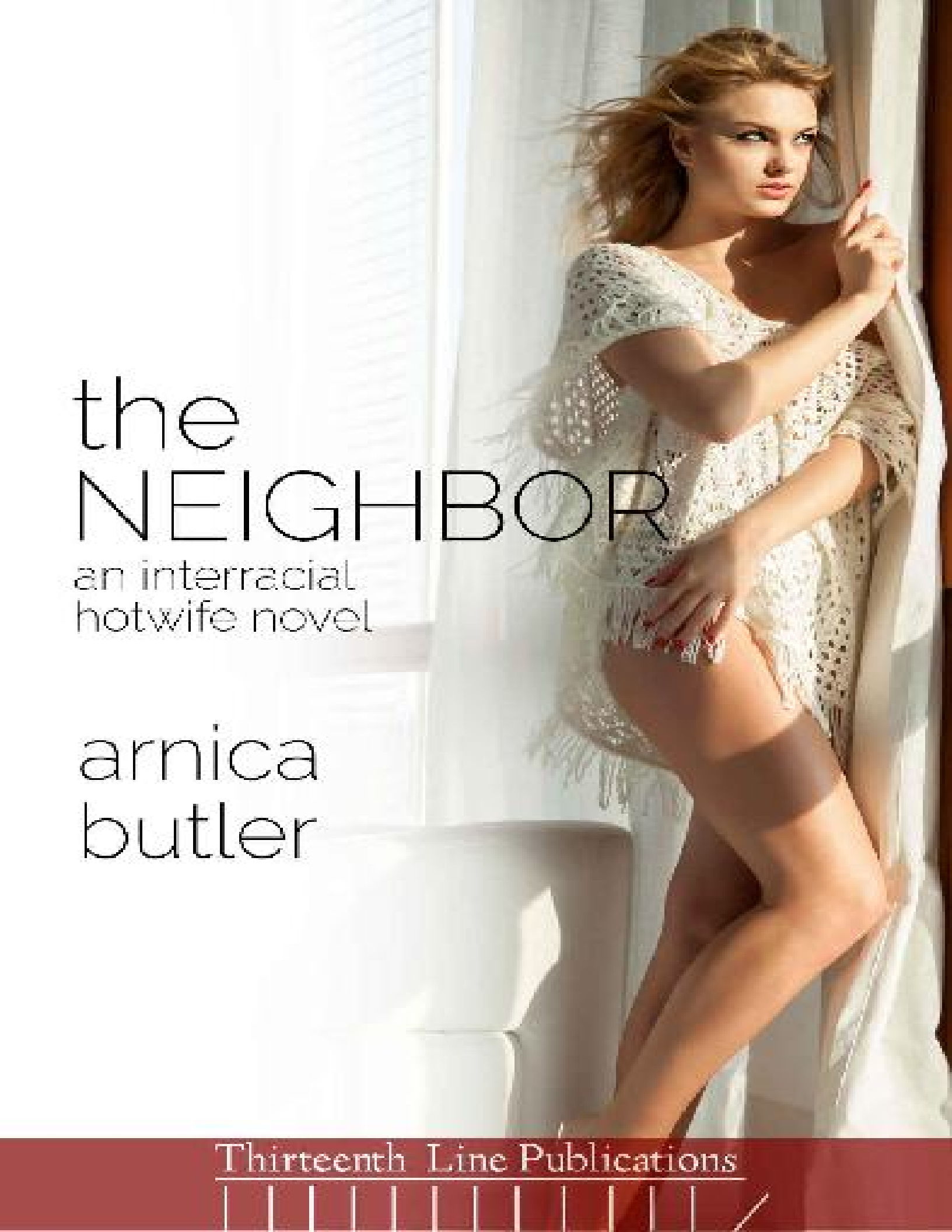


A woman with long, wavy blonde hair is posing in a white, short-sleeved lace dress. She is standing in front of a window with white blinds, which are partially open, allowing bright light to filter through. She is looking towards the camera with a slight smile, her right hand raised near her face. The overall mood is bright and elegant.

the NEIGHBOR

an interracial
hotwife novel

arnica
butler

Thirteenth Line Publications

THE NEIGHBOR

An Interracial Hotwife Novel

By Arnica Butler

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CHAPTER 1

“I think I see him.”

The words didn't make their way through Michael's mind immediately. Raine was standing in the late evening sunlight, hand-washing a pot she had taken out of the dishwasher (with the kind of sigh she reserved specifically for dishes *he* put in the dishwasher that she felt needed to be washed by hand). The sunlight glowed on her pale skin, giving her an angelic look, particularly on the features of her face that were so often referred to as doll-like: her heart-shaped lips that were always pursed, her upturned nose, her long lashes that so many people asked if they were extensions.

Michael was mildly annoyed by the pot, a little bubble of irritation in the simmering pool of their marital “disputes,” which had become increasingly frequent. They seemed, to him, to be a reflection of Raine's increasing annoyance with him and his habits, and he felt at a loss as to what, if anything, he could – or should – do about it.

“Psst,” she said. “He's here, I think. I think I see him.”

Michael's eyes lost their glaze. “Huh? Who?”

Raine turned to him, the features of her face unusually animated.

“The new guy, the tenant.”

Their rental property was located catty-corner to their house in a stylish neighborhood in Cleveland, where expansive lawns ran into each other without fences and old, restored houses were sold on the cheap to anyone who could make a living in a city that America frequently forgot existed.

Raine and Michael let a property manager handle everything about it, including finding a tenant, because they were only sitting on the house until real estate prices allowed them to make some money on it.

The rental house had belonged to Raine's mother, and had been left to them when she died, years before they moved to the neighborhood. It was only by strange coincidence that they had moved to their own home, so close to this one. They ordinarily distanced themselves from the renters or

even the idea that the property was theirs; after all, they didn't want to be landlords.

But the same family had lived there for ten years, and then they had renovated it to charge more rent to new families or up-and-coming singles who wanted an investment. Now, curiosity about who had rented it (for about twice the previous rent), got the better of them.

Michael stood up and walked over to the sink. Raine was absentmindedly turning the pot in her hands. He stood next to her, enjoying the warmth of her skin against his. Raine was in a loose-fitting blue dress with a severe, sexy plunge at the collar, and she had no bra on. It was a scaldingly hot day, even with the air conditioning running on high the air was wet and muggy inside. A light sheen covered her skin, and her pert breasts formed sweet peaks under the light cotton fabric, topped by the outlines of her nipples, which were hardened by the cool air-conditioning blowing over her chest into the shape (and, he knew, color) of pencil erasers..

Michael focused on the yard, and sure enough: through the drooping black locusts and a whimsical willow, he could see the new tenant on the deck of the house, seated in a chair from the patio set that had been hauled out and assembled for him a few days after he moved. He had a cellphone to one ear.

And he was also...

"Is he...?" Michael started to say, squinting.

Raine started scrubbing. "Oh my God," she said, chiding him in the name of political correctness. "But yes. Yes, he is," she whispered.

"Black" is the word they were both un-daring enough to say. Had they been brave enough to say aloud that he was black, they would have quickly followed that statement with: "But it doesn't *matter*."

It wasn't as if there were *no* black people living in Rocky River.

It wasn't as if it mattered to either of them.

It was more that, not only was he black in Rocky River, he was really, *really* black. His deep, ebony-colored skin contrasted sharply with the white t-shirt he was wearing.

Even at that distance, it was also plain to see that he was a well-built man. The t-shirt was snug on his chest, and though he was far away it was

clear to see that the bulges beneath it were not fat but pure muscle. His arms changed shades where muscle definition played with the sun.

“Hot,” Michael said dryly.

Raine, as expected, gave a nervous laugh and rolled her eyes. “Oh my God,” she said, and then she opened her mouth to say something else, but didn’t. She looked down at her pot and began scrubbing it with extreme concentration.

Michael felt a pang in his chest.

Was he mistaken, or did his wife seem... flustered?

Flustered by the thought of a black man living nearby?

Though he tried to keep it at bay, adrenaline poured into his blood, and his voice was almost shaky when he said:

“Let’s go over and introduce ourselves.”

The pot slipped out of Raine’s hands and she let out a nervous laugh. “Oh!” she exclaimed. “What? Introduce our... nah. We never do that.”

Then she looked through the window again.

Michael watched as her hand involuntarily went to her hair to smooth it. “We don’t... I mean. Well, it would be the nice thing to do but we don’t... do that. Right? We don’t want to know our neighbors... or our tenants. Especially. Our tenants...”

Raine’s voice faded away.

Michael leaned on the counter, at a loss as to what to say.

“What did you say he did, again?” she asked abruptly. She seemed almost alarmed.

“Uh... I can’t remember. Something in... healthcare, I feel like.” He was already turning to the credenza where he kept everything in a highly organized heap. He removed the information the property managers had sent to him, which included the tenant's application for their final approval.

Applicant’s Name: Gabriel Isaiah Knight.

In retrospect, it seemed rather obvious that he was black.

“Therapist, it says,” Michael said, after scanning the application. “Why?”

“Because he drives a Beemer,” Raine said, her finger outstretched at the sliver of driveway visible from their own yard.

Michael looked at her plainly. “A Beemer?” he said suggestively. “Wow. You can only see the side of it. Since when are you a car expert?”

Raine's mouth fell open as she looked at him. "Oh come on," she said. "Everyone knows a Beemer."

"Therapist, huh?" Michael said. "Maybe I'm in the wrong racket."

"Maybe it's some kind of cover story," Raine said.

Michael was amused. "Right. Let me guess... for being a drug dealer?"

"Michael!"

"A secret drug dealer who wants to keep a low profile, so he moves into the white outskirts of Cleveland and throws gang signs around discreetly?"

Raine looked wounded. "I wasn't saying that," she said. "I just... like, why is he here, though? He have kids or anything?"

"Single," Michael said.

Raine looked at him. "So why Rocky River?" she said. "This is a crazy place for a single... guy... to move in."

Michael looked at her and they both cracked up. "Single *black* guy, you mean."

"Well... single, like, I dunno... hot young guy, you know? I mean, this is a pretty sleepy neighborhood for..."

Michael smiled. "Young, hot guys."

They turned and looked out the window. The new black neighbor was definitely hot, and young, and did not look like the typical resident of Rocky River.

"Maybe he's gay," Raine said.

Michael snorted, and Raine shook her head at herself as soon as she did. New-neighbor certainly didn't sit like a gay man. He had the cocksure, space-consuming posture of an alpha male, his muscular thighs spread wide, his hand in a fist as he held his phone.

"Maybe he just likes all the MILFs," Michael mused.

As soon as he said it, he realized it was closest to what he had really been thinking. Fantasizing, almost. Raine wasn't a MILF yet, but she would be, eventually, and thinking about a guy like the new neighbor moving into the neighborhood to lure a creamy, fresh-faced little girl like Raine into the bedroom made Michael, surprisingly, very horny.

"We should go say 'hi,'" Michael said. Being turned on by the idea of the black man preying on his wife had triggered some kind of guilt in him,

and he was determined to act like a good neighbor and not a jackass white man who was paranoid about the one black guy in his neighborhood.

Anyway, Raine was surely going to veto the idea.

“Uh... okay,” she said, instead. She was untying her apron, an item she charmingly wore without fail while doing anything in the kitchen. “I just need to... go... this dress has no... change really quick.”

“You look fine,” Michael said, watching her as she turned. The curves of her small breasts peeked out of the denim-colored wraparound, hinting at what was underneath. It did look a little trashy, a little too revealing. She had good reason to change, but he found himself wanting her to wear it.

She looked down, right between her breasts, and adjusted the material. The fabric shifted over her thighs, lean and long.

Raine was pretty conservative when it came to her clothing: she didn't like it to be too revealing. This summer dress had been a gift from a friend, or it never would have been taken off the rack by Raine.

And yet, she seemed to be hesitating.

“Uh... nah,” she said. “I better do something.”

She hurried upstairs and Michael looked out the window at the neighbor to pass the time.

What *was* this guy's deal?

His BMW was spotless, shiny and looking brand-new. It seemed to be this year's model. Even his t-shirt looked somehow expensive: it was bright white and spotless.

Michael also wondered why he was out in the heat when they had central air in the house. It was a good cover story if things went poorly when they went over to meet him: he could always say he was wondering if something was wrong with the air conditioning, like a good landlord.

His mind started to drift, back to that strange place of discomfiting pleasure: thinking about a black man going after his MILF-like wife. A tingle traveled down his spine and right into his balls.

He closed his eyes and tried to steer his thoughts in another direction. What the fuck was wrong with him?

Raine's footsteps chattered down the stairs. “Okay,” she said.

She had been gone much longer than a change-of-clothes, Michael noted. She had donned her shortest pair of jean-shorts and a close-fitting white shirt, neither of which were particularly racy, but they were also quite

flattering. And her hair shoulder-length, light brown hair seemed carefully combed. His eyes fell on her glistening lips, stained with a cherry-red color in the center, giving her an appealing and even more doll-like appearance than usual.

“Did you put makeup on?” he asked.

Raine looked flustered for a moment and brought her fingers to her lips. “Just gloss,” she said quickly, almost snappily. “Why?”

Michael shrugged and hoped that the erection brewing in his pants was as mild as he thought it was. “Just noticed, is all.”

Raine sighed and walked stridently toward the back door. When she reached it, she paused, her hand on the knob. “Should we take something?” she said, making a face. “Some wine or something?”

“Let’s just say hello for now. We don’t want to scare him,” Michael said.

Raine’s tight shorts hugged her ass, and the small white shirt clung to the outlines of her satin bra, the lace edges a wave of bumps at the edges of her breasts. (The shirt would have looked better with no bra, Michael thought salaciously). He watched her small round bottom on her petite frame as she walked ahead of him to the edge of the porch.

She had her hand out for him to take, which was unusual these days. He joined his in hers and they started across the grass.

Yards in this area were rarely fenced, and theirs was no exception: a willow marked where all of the four yards met, but the path to the other yards was otherwise uninhibited.

The neighbor began to rise from his chair as soon as he saw them, his eyes watchful and his expression neutral but guarded. “Yeah. Call you back,” he said into the phone. He ended the call with a slow, calm motion, and without looking up from the screen, he said:

“Help you folks?”

His was a clean, Midwestern, middle-class accent. Polite, not overly helpful.

Michael froze, as he sensed the slightest bit of aggression in his movements.

“Oh... hi. We’re...uh, we’re Raine and Michael, we live over there. We, um, just wanted to introduce ourselves, say hello, welcome you to the neighborhood,” Raine said sweetly.

And then she began doing what she always did when she got nervous. She began talking. She couldn't stop herself.

"We're also, well, technically we're your landlords. But you don't deal with us," she added quickly. "Or you're, you know, we're not like, watching the house or anything. I don't want you to feel uncomfortable but I guess it would eventually come out..."

Michael looked at the neighbor while he sought Raine's hand and gave it a squeeze. She sensed she was blabbering unnecessarily, so she shut her mouth with a snap and her cheeks flushed.

The man's eyes moved over Raine's body. His expression was not possible to read, but something in his eyes burned as he looked at Raine. Not only that, Michael noted, he let his eyes rest on her breasts, and her legs, just a little longer than "appropriate."

By milliseconds, but nonetheless, too long.

He also seemed to be completely unapologetic about it. His eyes walked slowly back up her body, taking their time.

The silence, in the meantime, was mildly uncomfortable.

"Raine, you said," he finally intoned, not taking his eyes off of her. He did not crack a smile, or so much to make her feel less uncomfortable about her rambling.

"It's short for Lorraine," Raine said quickly. "I'm not... my parents weren't hippies or anything."

"No," the man said, reaching out to take her hand.

As the new neighbor enclosed Raine's small white hand in his (suggestively) gigantic black paw, Michael felt sure that he sensed a ripple traveling through his wife's body. The handshake, like his sizing-up of Raine's body, took a little longer than was customary or polite.

He turned to Michael with his hand extended. "Gabe," he said simply.

His hand was warm, large, and his handshake was firm with the slightest hint that he could crush things with the same grip.

Michael gave him the firmest shake he could muster.

"Sorry to be on guard," Gabe said, his tone and facial features expressionless. "I wasn't sure if y'all were coming over here to burn a cross in my yard or what."

He smiled the kind of smile it was impossible to read.

Raine looked horrified, but luckily didn't start talking again. Gabe turned his smile on her and softened it a bit. "Just jokin'," he said. "Anyway... y'all want a drink or something? I have, uh... well, water and whiskey."

Michael looked over at Raine, who had a glazed look in her eyes and was tipping slightly back and forth on her heels.

"Raine?" he asked.

Raine snapped out of her reverie. "I...yeah. No, um, I don't think we have, you know, time, right honey? Shoot, we should have brought you some wine. If that's all you have--"

She looked at Michael just as he squeezed her hand again.

"Well, that's too bad," Gabe said smoothly, and without hesitation. "We'll have to do it some other time. Thanks for coming by."

Both Raine and Michael were slightly stunned by the directness of his wrap-up, so they exchanged glances and made flustered noises before Michael said, "Yeah. Of course. Well, see you around."

Then he lifted his hand in a slow-motion wave, which made him feel very silly, and they turned and walked toward their house.

They said nothing to each other until they were safely into their own yard. They looked behind and saw that Gabe had gone inside and closed the door behind himself.

Raine did the same after following Michael inside, and when he turned to her she had her mouth open in a grin, a sure sign she wanted to share some gossip. "Oh my god," she said. "What *was* that?"

Michael looked at her. "What?" he asked, even though he knew what she meant by "that."

"He's... kind of scary," Raine said, briskly walking to the kitchen window and looking out of it at the catty-corner house. She put her fingers to her lips, as though she found the "kind of scary" Gabe more sensual than frightening.

"He's a good-looking guy," Michael suggested.

He had an odd compulsion to get his wife to talk about Gabe some more.

Raine tapped her fingers on her lower lip and said nothing.

"Sort of an alpha-male type. Don't women love that kind of thing?" Michael continued. He was willing her to agree, and to agree in great,

sordid detail.

Raine did not answer for a moment; she looked absorbed by her own thoughts and stared out the window. Then, as if she realized suddenly how bad that looked, she shook herself out of her stupor and shrugged theatrically. “*I* don’t. I mean, I guess some people do... but it’s, you know. Not for me.”

Michael’s gut felt cool. Raine was really flustered. Actually, genuinely flustered.

He wondered...

Even though it was out of character for him, and outside of their ordinary routine, and probably a very revealing thing to do, he couldn’t stop himself: he took a step toward his wife and slid his arm around her waist. His fingers found their way under the fabric of her shirt. Even as he pushed her hair to the side and nuzzled her neck, he was expecting her to squirm away and pat him on the arm, which was her signal for “not now.” His advances were spurned with such clockwork precision that he was already letting his hand drop and preparing to back away when he saw her lips part, and her eyelids grow heavy.

Then she surprised him completely by *not* moving away when his fingers continued beneath her shirt and along the bumps of her ribs, under the taut fabric of her bra, and to the soft center of her breast, where he found her nipple hard like a rubber eraser tip.

His other hand, like an appendage with a mind of its own, slipped into her jean shorts, and down to her panties, where it was a jolting surprise to find the satin fabric damp in the center between her legs.

And so, whatever it was that was happening began to be less important than the fact that his fingers were moving under the moist material of her underwear – and she wasn’t squirming away.

CHAPTER 2

Raine's spine was electrified from tip to tip, with a dull ache traveling from her tailbone, turning cold and exciting as it traveled up her back to her neck, spraying a rain of gooseflesh over her shoulders.

In part, it was the sensation of Michael's lips on her skin, dry and warm. His hand was working its way beneath her shirt, and his other hand was going to soon find that she was wet between her legs. As the ripples of pleasure traveled over her skin and her nipples grew hard, she gave herself over to the sensual delight of her husband touching her.

Why didn't they do this more often? Why was she so reluctant to have sex with him?

No sooner had the question formulated in her mind than she felt a pang of guilt, because the truth was actually quite dark.

The truth was that shaking the black neighbor's enormous hand had been arousing. The feel of his skin, the reverberations of his baritone voice, the way he had looked right at her body with an obvious hunger, had made her insides twist in ways she hadn't felt for ages.

It was all so perfectly cliché and *wrong*. She had actually found herself thinking about the size of his package. Right there on his porch, with her husband next to her, in the early evening, in this day and age. It had taken all of her willpower to keep her eyes from dropping to the bulge in his jeans, which she had already seen when he stood up as they were approaching.

It was big.

Enticing.

Even though her husband's hands were the hands on her body now, it was Gabe who had stirred all this arousal, Gabe who had created the ache between her thighs – not Michael.

Sure, it felt good to have her husband's lips on her shoulders and her husband's hands sliding down to the center of her legs, because she loved Michael and she *wanted* to feel the way she felt right now when Michael touched her.

But it also felt very, very wrong that Michael's touch only felt as good as it did because Gabe's handshake had made abdomen quiver and her panties wet.

She had the momentary thought that she had better behave as she usually did, and press her hand to Michael's before his fingers found their way to her panties, which she knew were soaked. Michael was no idiot, and he would wonder what was up with her, and surely he would not be unable to connect the dots here and conclude that she was turned on by the black man next door.

Her chest felt cool with guilt.

The problem was, she was enjoying herself too much to stop things. She wanted Michael's hand to find its way into her panties, and to feel his hot fingers on her clit. She wanted him to pull her shorts down and bend her over the counter and fill her up with his hard cock right here in the kitchen.

His fingers made a tantalizing sweep over her panties. Her eyelids grew heavy and she closed her eyes. She could not fight off the image of Gabe, standing up and walking toward them, his eyes taking a long, hungry walk all over her body. When Michael's fingers finally curled beneath the damp material of her underwear, she imagined that they were not his, but Gabe's wiry dark fingers plunging into her pussy.

She unbuttoned her own shorts when she felt Michael tugging her gently in the direction of the kitchen. She squirmed out of them and he went along with her, a slight noise of surprise coming from his mouth.

In her heart she knew, and she felt bad that, he would know that the interaction with the neighbor was making her behave differently. But the lust stirred up inside of her was overpowering her logic, and she shimmied out of the jean shorts and let them plop around her ankles. She stepped out of only one leg.

Michael was right there with her, tugging at her panties until they were just below her ass. The tenderness with which he had been kissing her neck and earlobes disappeared suddenly, and he roughly pushed her over the sink. She braced herself on the back of the counter and looked out the window as she felt him guiding the crown of his very hard cock toward her pussy.

She closed her eyes again as he rubbed the crown over her clit a few times. She pictured Gabe's cock, even though she tried hard not to. She had

never seen a black man's cock before, never been with a black man in any way. She wondered how dark it was, how large it was -

She tried to stop herself from having those thoughts, but to no avail. All they did was make her more turned on, so that when Michael sank into her pussy, pulling slightly on her hips to get her lined up with his cock, he plunged in with a loud slosh.

"You're so wet," he said, and she felt another pang of guilt. But it was overridden by her lust, and she pushed back against him and ground against his pelvis, driving his cock deep inside of her. She wanted to say something, and it didn't escape her notice that not only was she so wet, but he was so hard.

It took her almost no time at all to come. She was surprised at how quickly the sensation built up inside of her, and when she tried to wait a little longer so that she didn't have Michael pumping away at her after she already came, she failed at trying to distract herself. Her mind would not stop producing images of black cocks, of Gabe over her, one big hand in her hair and one on her ass, pulling her up close to him as he pounded his huge cock hard into her.

"Oh!" she yelled, as her climax overtook her. Her pussy welled up with juices and the sounds of Michael behind her became even sloppier. She could feel her pussy squeezing him in spasms. The high was incredible, mostly because it overtook her, instead of her having to concentrate carefully to get much out of sex at all.

She expected Michael to take longer to come than he did, but he filled her up almost immediately after she came, slamming hard and deep inside of her.

She had one last dirty, wrong thought as she imagined that the hot cum in her pussy had not come from her husband, but from Gabe. Would it feel any different inside of her?

The pleasant waves of her orgasm began to subside, and she felt horribly guilty for the things she was thinking. She felt a rush of blood rising to her cheeks, and she was glad that she could claim it was only the rush of sex if Michael asked her.

He slid from inside of her, and she reached behind herself to pull her panties over her hips. They were stretched and loose, and cool where she had made them damp.

She cleared her throat. The guilty feeling was cold and spreading to her limbs. She looked down at the sink and absent-mindedly turned on some water.

“Whoo!” she said, because silence made her nervous, especially when she had some secret to keep.

Michael was pulling up his own shorts. “Wow,” he said.

And then she braced herself for him to say something. She could almost hear him asking: “What brought that on?” She was racking her brains for a good answer, prepping herself for a way to shrug it off as the heat, or the time of the month, or a full moon.

But all Michael did was pull her hair away from her neck and kiss her. “That was fun,” he said. “I feel like a beer. You want one?”

Her heart pinged against her chest. Guilt and relief, and the dirty, fun thrill of having a secret filled her to the brim. She was almost shaking, so she put her hand on the counter. Gabe’s yard was empty.

“Is there any wine?” she asked unsteadily.

Because she really did need a drink.

CHAPTER 3

Columbus, where Michael spent a great deal of time on business, was muggier than usual. Michael had sweat inside his suit while outside, and then begun to chill once inside. His client, Jim Banks, was busy on his smartphone about every five minutes, for about five minutes, something he had ceased apologizing for and which was now making it difficult to carry on their meeting.

As a rule of thumb, it was extremely important in consulting to make people like Jim Banks think that they had all of your attention and time, so Michael had to resist the urge to take out his own phone and start conducting his own business, which sorely needed doing. He instead worked on a smooth line to start the conversation back up again and get to the point as soon as possible, the moment Jim got off his phone and asked, for the umpteenth time that day, “Now, where were we?”

But, as had happened frequently lately, his mind went wandering back to his wife, and his neighbor Gabe.

Since they’d had incredibly good sex on the kitchen counter several weeks ago, he was unable to stop replaying the sex, the meeting with Gabe, and his weird fantasies about his wife with Gabe. He couldn’t decide whether it tortured him or turned him to fire inside to think of Raine’s wet pussy after she met Gabe, or to think about her beneath the hulking mass of the black neighbor with her legs spread wide open.

All it took was a few spare moments, or the sight of a silver BMW, or seeing another black guy (of which there were many in Cleveland, just not in their neighborhood), and his thoughts went spinning out of control.

And a BMW had just driven by.

It was in this erotic reverie that a very astonishing thing happened.

At first, he assumed it was his imagination, and also his tendency to think that most black people looked alike. But a tall, muscled, well-dressed black man came through the rotating doors of the hotel lobby and walked directly toward the lounge where Michael was seated with his client.

And he looked *exactly* like Gabe.

It then became almost dreamlike, watching him as he approached, because the closer he got, the more he looked like Gabe.

Michael looked at Jim, hoping the client would tether him to reality. Surely he was just imposing his fantasies about Gabe on any fit black man he saw. He brought his water to his mouth and took a long drink, mostly to cover his face and block out the image of the man so he wouldn't be caught staring.

Or in case it was Gabe, whom it would be extremely odd to run into here.

Jesus, Michael, he told himself. It's not your fucking neighbor. It's just a black guy.

He set the water down, relieved that the man had sat to the left of him, and did not appear to recognize him. Definitely not Gabe.

"You okay, man?" Jim asked. He was looking at the water.

"It's the heat," Michael said smoothly. "I forget to hydrate and then I'm just overtaken by thirst. Is everything okay on your end?" he asked, looking at the phone in Jim's hand.

"I really apologize," Jim said. "It's been a hell of a day and now I have a major... thing... here. Can I get the check and reschedule with you for another time?"

"We can absolutely reschedule, but don't even think of getting the check. If you have to go, you have to go. I understand the value of your time."

Jim's phone was already buzzing in his hand. "I really, I'm sorry, it's a shitshow – Hi Denise – yeah, Michael, I'll put Denise in touch with you – yeah," he said, rising from the table. "I've gotta get in touch with Charles either way, Denise, can't you try to..."

Michael shook his napkin out over his lap and put his elbows on the table, his eyes searching for the waiter. He was annoyed that he had booked a room in Columbus so he wouldn't have to drive back after drinking with Jim, annoyed that he was missing out on time with his wife, and annoyed that he would have to reschedule this meeting and would not be getting anywhere with Jim anytime soon.

He took out his phone, because the waiter was nowhere to be found. He supposed he could just drink whatever Jim had ordered, and eat his

appetizer (Jim always ordered food but never ate it, so not much really changed by the fact that he had left).

Maybe he could cancel his hotel reservation and get back to Cleveland tonight. It was only two hours.

Maybe he would surprise Raine.

He started typing her a message. More likely than not she had scheduled something with friends, which was something he always enjoyed stewing about a little.

Or maybe she had a lover with her, and he could catch them in the act.

As he was typing, he saw a white couple approach the table where the black man was sitting. He heard a pleasant laugh, a deep baritone voice, and then – and he was sure of this – he heard the woman say “Gabriel.”

His heart stopped cold, though he couldn’t say why. So what if it was his neighbor Gabe? It was a coincidence, but why would that make him feel like he felt right now, with his pulse accelerating and his forehead forming a sheen of sweat as his insides turned to mush?

The waiter appeared magically in front of him. “Sir, I couldn’t help but notice that the party you were with seems to have departed. Would you like me to cancel his order? I can cancel yours as well.”

Michael took a moment to steal a sideways glance at the party to the left of him. Gabe’s features were unmistakable: it was definitely him. A very attractive blonde woman and a brown-haired man were seated with him, and something seemed quite odd about the way they were sitting and interacting.

“I... is there any way I could move to... back there, at one of those little tables?” he asked, thinking quickly. “I’ll take my drink *over there*.”

“Should I cancel the gentleman’s order?” the waiter asked.

“Yeah, do that,” Michael said, rising up and turning his back on the table with Gabe and the white couple, taking his water glass with him.

The waiter said nothing more and Michael slunk away to a bank of benches on a wall behind the bar, tucked away so that he could look at Gabe and his friends sideways from a distance and probably still have good cover.

Once seated, he snuck another glance at the table as the waiter brought him his drink. “I’ll take another when you get a chance,” Michael

said, not even thinking about how that might look. The waiter was unaffected and simply bowed slightly in response to the request.

When he left, the view of the table was unobstructed.

It occurred to him almost immediately that he must just be seeing Gabe with some of his clients. He was a therapist after all. Probably a marriage therapist.

Disappointed, he began to wonder if he should pop over and say something to him, the coincidence of running into him a whole city away being quite astounding.

But there was something strange about the way they were sitting there. Something about the arrangement of the three of them, the way that the woman was looking at Gabe, almost flirtatiously.

He took a sip of his whiskey soda. He was imagining things. Imagining things because he had his own really weird fantasies and he was imposing them on other people in order to make himself feel less weird about constantly imagining his wife being fucked by a black man.

The idea to message Raine took over his mind as though he barely had control over it. The phone was in his hand and his fingers were typing to her as though they had a mind of their own. He didn't even check his message or deliberate about it; he was excited, flying high.

[Me]: *You'll never guess who I'm looking at in this bar in Columbus.*

[Me]: *He's here with this couple and it's really weird.*

Raine was probably out with friends, he thought immediately. Or at yoga, or out flirting with some guy at a bar. He'd even gone so far as to have his doubts about his wife, that she might be cheating on him, that her disinterest in sex with him was because of that. Raine had kept mum about Gabe, and the hot sex they'd had on the counter (as well as the subsequently more interesting and passionate, and frequent, encounters they'd had since). Maybe it was all in his mind, his imagination about what his wife was thinking or what he wanted her to think.

The feeling in his stomach when his phone buzzed on the table took him back a decade. The queasy excitement of not knowing how someone would react to a text, or if a girl would call you back, had been absent from

his life for so long he had forgotten how it felt. And yet here it was, fresh and new. It accelerated to a full-on high when he read Raine's message.

[Raine]: *Not Gabe?!!*

His stomach coiled up tightly. Why would she guess exactly that? Why was she thinking about him?

But as soon as he had these thoughts, he dismissed them for the excitement of telling her about it. He positioned himself so that he could hold his phone in front of him and look over the top of it at the threesome.

And there it was. The odd thing. The woman had her hand on her husband's, and was making lazy trails up and down his arm with her fingertips. It was a very sexual way to be touching someone in that particular context, but it wasn't what made it odd. She was talking, and her eyes were on Gabe like he was a steak and she hadn't eaten in twenty days.

But more importantly – *most importantly* – she had her foot on his shin under the table.

Gabe's shin.

He picked up his drink while sticking the phone under the table and attempting to take a photo, but it was disappointingly aimed in completely the wrong direction and only showed the floor and some table legs.

He typed to Raine.

[Me]: *how'd you know? I'm looking at him with this couple and the woman is playing footsie with him under the table.*

He waited, watching the group from the corner of his eye, his mind going in circles on overdrive. He was getting an erection, his blood was moving fast, and he didn't even understand why.

[Raine]: *No way. The woman is playing footsie with GABE? Is the other guy her husband? What are they doing? Where are you?*

A mixture of emotions swamped him as he read the text. Why would Raine be so interested in this? And yet, he wanted her to be, he was

enjoying the fact that she was.

[Me]: *Im trying to take a picture. At Hyatt bar for meeting with Expro exec and he bailed, and here came G. The two are definitely a couple and she is touching her husband on top of the table and playing footsie with G under the table*

Raine wrote back almost immediately.

[Raine]: *Scandalous. What are they doing now? Has he seen you?*

[Me]: *He hasn't seen me. They're talking and having drinks and flirting with each other, it looks like.*

There was a long and delicious pause, and he intermittently watched the action at Gabe's table and the three bouncing dots on his phone indicating the Raine was typing something, imagining her curled up on the couch, biting her lip, excited for details.

It was a strange situation, but regardless of why or what it was about, Michael did know that it felt good to be having an *exciting* conversation with Raine, one in which they were on the same side and there was an element of surprise and eroticism to it. Even if that eroticism was only one-sided, even if it was weird. It was there. And it felt good.

[Raine]: *Do you think the wife is having an affair and the husband doesn't know about it? Is it just them? Not his girlfriend or anything?*

And then almost immediately:

[Raine]: *Okay don't think I'm weird but I've been spying on his house and I don't think he has a girlfriend.*

[Raine]: *Does it seem like they know each other or they just met?*

His wife's enthusiasm was weird, all right. Suspicious. But for some reason Michael really enjoyed the twisted feeling it gave him that she was so interested in the possibility that a woman was having an affair with Gabe, right under her husband's nose.

And then he saw that he had typed this message, without even thinking much about it consciously:

[Me]: *Oh so you've been spying on him have you. Are you trying to tell me something?*

And he had sent it.

His stomach dropped. What the hell was he doing?

And then, when Raine's response came in almost immediately and he read it, it dropped again, but the sensation was thrilling.

[Raine]: *Tell you something... like that I have a secret crush on our neighbor?*

But there was no time to think of a good response to that, because at Gabe's table the threesome were all standing up. The woman drank her wine and set the glass down, smiled at her husband, and turned to walk toward the exit. The husband walked toward the bar, taking out his wallet as if to pay the tab.

Michael watched, an erection throbbing, as Gabe followed the woman to the doorway. She stopped and turned toward him, and he moved in very, very close. She leaned against the door frame – a large wooden archway leading out to the lobby, and Gabe raised his hand and braced himself against the frame as he leaned in closer and drew his finger from the neckline of her dress down the center of the bodice, right to her crotch, which he tapped with his finger. All the while he was talking to her, and she seemed to melt right into the woodwork as he did.

A movement caught Michael's eye as the husband turned away from the bar and began walking toward Gabe and the woman.

Gabe didn't flinch as he looked over at the husband, and neither did the man. The husband slipped his arm around the woman's waist and Gabe

moved out of his way, but not as though he had been caught doing something he shouldn't. It was more like an orchestrated, friendly move.

And then they all walked slowly to the elevators, Gabe with his hand on the woman's ass.

Right in front of the other man.

The doors closed on the clutch of three people closing in on each other, smiles on their faces, Gabe with his hand right back at the dent in the center of the woman's dress, and the husband or boyfriend just smiling away.

Michael had completely forgotten Raine's last text. He typed clumsily, his hands trembling with excitement.

[Me]: *You are never going to believe what I just saw*

He waited for Raine's response, and ordered another drink as the waiter passed by. He was getting drunk, he was high on the excitement of what he was seeing, and he found himself enjoying the kind of fun he hadn't had since he was a much younger man. Sexual, illicit fun.

He re-read Raine's last message as he waited for her to type her response, and the words curled inside of him like a drug. *A secret crush on our neighbor.*

It was all-too-easy to picture Raine in the place of the woman he had just seen, all too easy to envision Gabe's finger sliding down the length of her torso and stopping right at her pussy, tapping it through the fabric, marking it as his own.

Raine's message, at last, appeared on the screen as the phone buzzed in his hand.

[Raine]: *Tell me*

He pictured a much more sultry Raine on the couch, her feet curled beneath her, her pinkie finger between her teeth, her cheeks flushed with excitement. Raine wearing a dress more like the one the woman who had disappeared with Gabe and another man for what appeared to be a very wild time upstairs was wearing: a black dress, short and form-fitting, clunky jewelry like a collar around her neck.

He had an idea, and it was a ludicrous idea, but he typed away nonetheless.

[Me]: *I could tell you but I think it would be so much more fun if you would come here and see for yourself.*

After a long pause, during which his heart beat wildly with the kind of excitement he had thought was long-dead and buried in his life, Raine replied.

[Raine]: *Come? There?*

And then, before he could type his reply:

[Raine]: *really?*

He typed a few hesitant replies, but the whiskey and the scene he had witnessed had gone to his head. He deleted them and took a more aggressive tone on.

[Me]: *it's just two hours. Come have some drinks at the bar with me, I'm on a stakeout. I have a nice suite, we can order in.*

And then he added, so she wouldn't even have a chance to say it:

[Me]: *cancel class. we'll do something fun in the morning and be back by the evening*

Raine took a while to write back. Columbus was, indeed, two hours away. He knew that maybe the fun of the evening would fade by then, but maybe it wouldn't. Raine would probably not be up for it. She was not an impulsive person.

So he was mildly surprised, and very excited, when she wrote back:

[Raine]: *A real stakeout? Well okay then. Send me the address.
I'll leave in like ten.*

CHAPTER 4

Raine drove much faster than she ordinarily would have, with the windows down and the music loud. The fact that 80s music qualified as “oldies” didn’t even bother her the way it usually did, and the air was warm and magical so she put a hand out the window and rode the waves of the highway wind.

Her mood was buoyant for the first time in a very, very long time. She knew that some of the things making her float so high were naughty, had to do with Gabe and her... what would you call it? Attraction to him? “Attraction” might be the wrong word. It was more like a benign fascination. She enjoyed fantasizing about him. She would never *do* anything with him of course, but she liked the *idea* of it. She liked that Gabe was somehow present in this mysterious “thing” that Michael had seen.

But part of what elevated her mood so much was just the fact that Michael had invited her to Columbus. He had been going there on business trips frequently, which was to be expected. Columbus was the sort of city people moved to, the kind of place where businesses grew and things got better. Cleveland had hospitals and an orchestra and inexpensive housing. A lot of people commuted; there was nothing unusual about that. Nothing unusual about staying in the city overnight.

But like any wife, Raine garnered suspicions about what her husband was doing. If he seemed distant, or didn’t want to have sex, or stayed an extra day, she assumed that he was having an affair. The whole idea of an affair had blossomed in her imagination to a full-fledged, wild nightmare. It had trapped her in a terrible place: she knew it was all in her imagination, so she was afraid to confront him about it. But she felt like it was real, and she couldn’t stop feeling that way.

Michael never asked her to come with him anymore. She had started to assume “the affair” was the reason. Either that or that he just didn’t care anymore about seeing her.

But now, now she was on her way and he seemed enthusiastic about her coming. She didn’t know what awaited her, and she hoped it wouldn’t

be disappointing.

But for the whole two-hour drive, the elation didn't wear off, and she was glowing and shaky with anticipation when she walked into the marble-encrusted lobby of the Hyatt and looked for the bar where Michael had said he would meet her. She gave herself a glance in the mirrored wall by the elevators. Michael had asked her to wear something sexy, which was another thing that had made her glow, and she was pleased with her reflection in the mirror.

She was wearing a shorter-than-usual sheath dress, which billowed a little at her hips and made her look smaller as a result, and she had paired it with a tight black shirt with a low neckline that she rarely wore.

By most people's standards it was quite a conservative outfit, but it was cute and it looked good on her, and, anyway, it was the sexiest thing she owned. She admired her legs, which she rarely showed so much of, and the line that they made, thanks to the tall black pumps she was wearing.

She walked briskly toward the bar. Ordinarily she dreaded going someplace she wasn't familiar with and looking for someone she knew, but tonight was an exception because she was still, even after all that driving, flying high on the novelty of the situation, the peripheral presence of Gabe, the danger and excitement, and the fact that her husband had bothered to invite her.

The bar had gotten fairly crowded. By now it was 9:30pm and everyone in the bar seemed to have walked out of a boardroom meeting and dived into a martini.

She spotted Michael right away, and her heart skipped a beat. That was something that hadn't happened for a long time, she thought. His sandy-brown, nearly blonde hair was caught in the light of the bar, and he had a light sprinkling of stubble on his jaw.

She worried for a moment that he would be too drunk to be any fun – after all, he had been waiting here alone, probably drinking. She would either have to catch up or consider the evening a write off...

He stood up when he saw her, his eyes moving up and down her body and a smile on his face. The kind of smile she hadn't seen for a long time.

"Thank God you're here," he said. "My kidneys are going to burst."

He took her by the shoulders as she made a face with her mouth open and said, "What?"

“Watch the elevator,” he said, and pointed toward the lobby. “And see if Gabe comes out, and who he’s with. I have to go piss, I’ll be right back and explain everything.”

He started to jog away, as she looked at him with bewilderment, but he turned around and kissed her on the mouth wetly. “Muah! I’m so happy you’re here. I just really have to whizz.”

She watched him go and turned her head slowly back to the elevator, wondering what it was that Gabe was doing here of all places, and who he was with that made it so crucial for her to drive all the way to Columbus.

She reached for the tall glass of clear liquid on the table and sniffed it. When no scent was revealed by the experiment she cautiously took a sip.

Water.

She kept her eyes on the elevator and ran through all the scenarios she could think of, and then some that were utterly preposterous. She wondered what it actually was, and how disappointing it might be.

“Okay,” Michael said, slumping into the booth with his hands palm-down on the table. He paused to tilt her chin up and kiss her on the mouth. His lips were dry and warm, and the kiss was passionate. Something stirred inside of her.

“Now,” he said. “Here is what has happened: I saw Gabe over there,” he pointed at a small table where two large women were now sitting and complaining loudly about their bosses. “And he was there alone and then this guy, and what looks to be his wife, walk in and sit down with him.”

“Right. A guy and his wife walk into a bar.”

He gave her a smile but kept going. He was clearly very excited to tell her what had happened.

“And *then*, I start to feel like something is weird. Just, you know... “off” somehow. I mean, the way they were sitting, it was weird. And so then I start to see things like, she’s playing footsie with Gabe under the table, and all this.”

“With Gabe? And did the husband know?”

“That’s just it. I thought he didn’t, and I was like, ‘ooh, you poor schmuck.’ And then he got up to pay the bill, and the wife and Gabe walked over to the doorway and he just like, flat out made out with her. And the thing is... the husband didn’t seem to care. *In fact*, I know he didn’t care at

all, because they all went upstairs together in the same elevator and they were... you know. Really close.”

She shook her head in disbelief. “There’s gotta be some explanation...”

“He touched her right on the crotch, right in plain view of that guy.”

Raine paused. “And he saw it?”

“Yes. And then they just went upstairs. But, okay, that isn’t the best part. The *best* part is I get to talking to this guy, who’s left now, and I was a little more drunk then, now I’m drinking water, and I say to him, because it’s so terribly weird, hey man, what do you make of this thing I saw?”

Raine raised her eyebrows.

“And *he says*, ‘oh, they’re probably swingers. Or... no, she’s probably a ‘hotwife.’”

“A ‘hotwife,’” Raine repeated subconsciously.

“Yeah, a ‘hotwife.’ Do you know what that is?”

Raine looked at him strangely. “What does that even *mean*?”

“That’s what I said!” Michael whisper-yelled. “And he tells me. You ready for this?”

Raine only hesitated a moment before nodding.

“So there are some men who enjoy watching their significant others, you know, have sex with someone else.”

Raine cocked her head, trying to make sure that she had heard him correctly. “Huh? They have sex with someone else? Like, the women have sex with another man?”

He nodded.

Raine shook her head. “No way.”

Michael took out his phone. “I pretty much said the same thing, and so this guy showed me all these websites, and forums, and all this stuff. Here,” he handed her the phone, and she started looking at the screen, but her mouth fell open almost immediately and she set it down on the table and pushed it away when an image of a girl with a cock in her mouth looking at the camera erupted on the screen. “Oh my gosh!” she said.

Her eyes, though, betrayed her curiosity. Did the caption under that photo say: “When your girlfriend gives head to your best friend?”

She spun the phone back toward her so she could read the caption. Her eyes went wide again. “I don’t... I can’t believe this.”

And she couldn't. Raine was a pretty conservative person in general. Not so much politically conservative, in that sense of the word, but she preferred things pretty standard when it came to sex, and marriage, and her clothing choices. It wasn't that she was church-y; she just didn't feel especially confident about... well, anything like that.

But the image had burned into her mind, and though she wouldn't have admitted it, even to herself at that moment, it was pushing her buttons a little. The same feverish wave of excitement that had overtaken her the night they had met their neighbor, and occasionally since then when she had given into thoughts about him, started to creep all over her skin.

She brought her hand to her neck and rubbed it, looking sideways as though she were concerned that someone was watching them – watching her, specifically – looking at dirty images on the phone together.

The feeling that overcame her wasn't necessarily embarrassment, however. It was almost... fun... doing this very illicit thing.

A waiter came at that moment and brought a whiskey and a white wine to the table. She looked up at him curiously, then got flustered because the dirty image on the phone was still glaring at the ceiling.

The waiter seemed not to notice, or care.

"I didn't -" she started to say.

"I ordered it," Michael said, and he clinked his glass to hers. "I was taking a break but now that you're here I can get back to the whiskey."

She sipped her wine. Then, in a cavalier mood that rarely overtook her, she drank it in gulps. She had a lot of catching up to do, and these cock pictures and "hotwives" were way out of her comfort zone. The alcohol might help.

"So," she said, leaning on her elbows and getting closer to Michael, who was looking at her with his eyebrows raised with a very impressed expression on his face, "I still don't get it... what does this have to do with Gabe?"

Michael waved at the passing waiter and ordered her another drink, which she did not object to. The naughty aspect of what they were doing was going to her head. She knew she'd pay for it tomorrow if she had even one more glass of wine, but she knew already that she would drink it. Maybe even another. Why not?

“So this is the thing,” Michael said, and he also leaned toward her until their heads were almost touching. She could smell his clothing, the faintest hint of his aftershave, his skin. It was so rare for them to spend time this close together, to be conspiring. A flush came over her, and her skin felt hot.

“This guy at the bar, the one I was talking to, said maybe our neighbor is what they call a ‘bull.’”

Raine laughed and covered her mouth. The laugh had escaped her and was the kind of laugh you reserve for things that are too scandalous to be real.

“A *bull*?” she whispered, her eyes glistening.

The word had traveled right through her, with all of its connotations, and even though she was feigning complete innocence, she understood perfectly what that was supposed to mean. Once again, she remembered the outline of Gabe’s cock in his jeans, the way it had made her feel that she even dared to *look* at it, let alone contemplate... touching it...

She rubbed her hand on her leg. “Tell me that’s not what... not what I think... it is...”

The waiter happened to bring her wine at that exact moment, and she drank a few gulps before setting it down.

She wasn’t, though, as scandalized as she was pretending to be. This was kind of an act, an act she’d made part of her identity for such a long time that it came naturally to her. Deep down inside, however, she knew that she wasn’t as flustered as she pretended to be, nor as un-curious as she acted like. Her eyes dropped to the phone, which had unfortunately gone to screen saver. She craved looking at the image again.

Her heart beat faster. Michael was nodding. “It means *exactly* what you think it means. And -”

He dropped his voice and looked around before leaning even closer, so she knew before he said it that he was going to say something about Gabe being black. “Apparently,” he whispered, “there are a lot of black guys who do this, like almost professionally, for white couples.” He sat back a little. “And I know what you’re going to say,” he said, palm out toward her, “but this guy showed me all these websites -”

He had picked up the phone and was thumbing the screen. Raine snatched it away from him and looked around sharply. “Don’t!” she said,

her eyes looking around the room. "I believe you, okay?"

She was smiling, she could feel it on her face. Inside, she was *dying* to look at these websites, to peruse them at her own leisure, to see exactly what this was all about. But it seemed inappropriate as hell to do it in the bar like this.

"So," she said, clearing her throat as though they needed to change the subject. "What are you staking out?"

Michael smiled. "I mean, *them*. That seems like it was exactly what was going on there. These people, they couldn't be more different, and they... I don't know. They were touching each other but they didn't seem like friends. And then Gabe put his hand on her over there, and the husband saw -"

"How do you know it was her husband?" she interjected. She loved to play devil's advocate and she was having fun with it now, especially because the wine was going to her head.

"Well, he came with her, they were holding hands. I dunno. They looked like they belonged together."

"Hmm," she took a sip of her wine. "They're not just good friends maybe?"

"Not if he touched her like he did."

She took another sip of her wine. "And how was that?"

Michael leaned back in his chair, his head cocked. "Okay. So... stand up."

"What?"

"Stand up," he said. "I'll show you."

Raine ordinarily would have done no such thing, but the second glass of wine was nearly gone and it had gone straight to her head. Saucily, she stood up. She adjusted her skirt.

"Nice gams by the way," Michael said, smiling.

His words burned on her skin.

"Okay, so... he went like this."

And then suddenly, he was trailing a finger down her torso. The light touch burned her skin through the material of her shirt, getting hotter until he went past the waistline, reached the mound of her pussy, and then *tapped* on it.

Her cheeks got red and she looked quickly around before plopping back into her seat. “Oh my God,” she said.

Her spine tingled, but she realized that the feeling she was having wasn’t embarrassment. It was warmer, more like liquor. Intoxicating. She almost *liked* the idea of everyone watching in the bar. And she had *loved* the way Michael looked at her while he was doing it.

He sat down slowly, nodding his head. “See what I mean? And the guy looked right at him, and then they walked over there...” he indicated the elevator, “and they went up, together. Oh, and Gabe was practically holding on to her ass on the way over.”

She leaned back in her seat. Her face was hot, her whole body was scorched. She felt like fanning herself but thought it would be a little clichéd.

“So... what do they do, then?” she asked.

The waiter was approaching, and giving her a look as he did. His eyes fell on the empty glass and she nodded. She would have one more. Sure. But she couldn’t be interrupted.

Michael paused as the waiter asked him if he wanted another whiskey, which he did. Then he waited until the waiter was out of earshot. “So I guess... this is based on what I read... I guess the guy, the husband, he, you know, just sits there and watches usually.”

Raine’s mouth fell open.

Her stomach felt like a bag of serpents, though. The warm tingle was red-hot, or maybe ice-cold now, traveling all over her body. “No way,” she said.

To her surprise, though, she was already visualizing it. It wasn’t as if she hadn’t given Gabe any thought at all, before. What his body might look like without a t-shirt, how his skin might feel. What it would be like to kiss a man like that.

“So what are we staking out? Just to see when they come back down?”

Michael shook his head. “Yeah,” he said. Then he laughed. “I guess, I don’t know. It’s really silly, right? But I can’t *not* wait it out, you know?”

Raine smiled.

It had been such a long time, she realized suddenly, since they’d even been out on a date. And those dates had always seemed sort of forced. They

didn't talk much, or connect very much. It often seemed like neither one of them actually wanted to be there.

But this was much different.

Raine shifted in her seat. "Yeah, okay," she said. "I'm in. Let's stake them out. All night if we have to."

Michael liked her joke. The pleasure on his face was evident and it made her glow from the inside out.

This might be weird, she thought, but it was fun.

She scooted her chair around to his side of the table, so they were sitting side by side. He jokingly lifted a heavy menu in front of them, and they sank below the eyeline and peered over the top.

"This is good," she said. "But I think we need an appetizer or something."

CHAPTER 5

They were getting good and drunk, and Raine had her hands on his thigh and a cherry in her mouth when the white couple Gabe had gone upstairs with came tumbling out of the elevator at almost one am.

And she looked... spectacularly well-fucked.

When she had gone upstairs she had been a prim-looking blonde in a tight black dress. Her hair had been coiled up in a stylish bun with no loose strands in sight, and her makeup had been as flawless as a TV anchor's.

The dress was back on, but it looked a little hasty somehow. The shoulder slouched too much, and a strap of black bra hung loose on one side. Her hair was down, curly as though it had gotten damp with sweat, tangled and messy. One strand clung to her face as though glued there, and it didn't take a genius to figure out what the glue might have been.

The tidy lipstick she had been wearing was all gone, and the skin around her mouth was slightly reddened. Her mascara was streaked down one cheek, looking like she had tried to wipe it off and failed. Michael could only imagine what the rest of her looked like, beneath the dress, if that's what her face looked like.

"That's them," he said. His erection, which had never really gone away, was coming back in full force again.

"They're... all over each other," Raine said, almost disbelievingly.

They stared at the couple as they clung to each other, paused in the lobby to kiss, and then stumbled toward the door, grabbing at each other's bodies like two teenagers in heat. The woman laughed in the direction of a scowling desk clerk.

"She looked..." Raine said, but didn't finish her sentence. She covered her mouth. "Oh my God. Do you think...?"

Michael shook his head. "I mean, the evidence speaks for itself. And Gabe is nowhere to be found."

Raine stared at the revolving door the two had disappeared from. A bell rang near the bar. "Last call," the bartender called out.

Except for Raine and Michael, there were only a few people left in the bar. An older, lonely man, whose red-rimmed eyes stared listlessly at the

wall behind the bartender, and a pair who had originally looked as though they hated each other and now seemed ready to go to bed together.

"I guess that's it for our stakeout," Michael said.

Raine smiled. "What now?" she said suggestively. She tapped her lips. "Wow. I am not going to be able to look at Gabe the same way again."

Michael straightened up and waved at the waiter for the check.

"Hmm," he said. "How often *are* you looking at Gabe?"

He wasn't sure exactly what response he had been expecting, but certainly it wasn't the one he got. Raine was very tipsy, and her face was already flushed, but the red color on her cheeks deepened and she grew so flustered she was unable to muster a response. Her lips quivered and she looked away.

"You know what I meant," she said quietly, as Michael stared at her in bemused disbelief.

He decided – or rather, the many drinks he had consumed decided for him – to venture into the unknown.

"You know it's okay," he said, trying to make himself sound as casual as possible. "He's a good-looking man."

Raine pulled her shoulders together and looked at him, making a face that she made when she found something too embarrassing to laugh off but wanted to make it look like she could.

"Oh. Well maybe he could be *our* bull, then. If you don't mind and all."

The comment fell onto the table as heavily as if a lead anvil had fallen from the ceiling. Her mouth fell open and he could see from the wild look in her eyes that she wished she could take it back. As for Michael himself, his blood boiled. There was so much energy between them suddenly that he was surprised the air didn't warp.

A too-long pause ensued, as they looked at each other over the table. Michael didn't dare say anything, because as much as it would have been easy to make a joke and give Raine an exit strategy, he didn't really want to. He almost wanted to take her suggestion seriously, to let her know he was taking it seriously. "Maybe he could," he wanted to say.

Well. He half-wanted to say that. He also half-wished he could extricate himself from this place they had stumbled into. It felt profoundly uncomfortable to even be contemplating such a thing, especially now that it

was in the realm of reality and not just pure fantasy. After all, bulls really did exist, and their neighbor really did seem to be one of them, and Michael's wife really did seem to be flustered by the thought of him.

It was his turn to clear his throat. He slid his hand across the table and took hers in it. "Let's go to our room," he said, and was immediately glad that it was what he had chosen to say. It seemed to smooth things over without erasing the possibility – the illicit, dark, cavalier, naughty possibility – of Gabe the neighborhood bull.

As they stepped into the elevator Raine gave him a nervous smile. Or perhaps it was a dirty smile, a knowing smile. It was the kind of exchange they never had anymore, where it felt like the two of them knew something that no one else did.

The doors closed and they looked at each other for only a second before he moved toward her and pushed her back into the wall. She was warm, receptive, opening up beneath his hands and fingers. He put his mouth on hers and it welcomed him in readily, their tongues darting around each other's, teeth nibbling at lips.

He moved his hands under the skirt she was wearing, a nice short surprise. The next surprise was to find her inner thighs hot and mildly damp with the sticky sheen of her juices. She parted her legs for him, and hooked an ankle around his leg to spread them open enough for him to hook a finger under the material of her underwear and dip into the nectar of her pussy.

The elevator bell dinged, and they felt the floor rushing up to meet them. Reluctantly, he stepped away from her and looked at the floor number: it was not theirs. She pushed her skirt down and he stood next to her, trying not to breathe too heavily as they waited for the doors to open.

In the mirror on the side of the doors, they looked younger, more beautiful than ever, and a lot like two teenagers who had gotten caught making out.

An older couple wrapped in towels from the hotel pool looked them up and down warily and then entered the elevator in silence. They stood in front of them with stiff backs as the elevator continued its ascent, two floors up. Michael touched Raine's pinky finger with his, and she smiled.

When the couple left and the doors closed behind them, he moved in on her again.

They tumbled into the corridor when the elevator stopped. His balls were blue, he was so turned on, and he hadn't felt like this in such a long time.

She was in front of him and he had one hand beneath her silk blouse as he fished the card key out of his pocket. He loved the handfuls of her breasts, the feel of her nipples beneath his palms, but they hardly ever had sex in a way that made it very easy for him to get his hands on her.

He laughed into the back of her neck as he struggled with the key. He couldn't concentrate on getting it out, getting it right. It didn't help that she was squirming in his hands, that her skin was hot and that she was bumping her ass up against him.

At last, after several failed attempts, the door light turned green, and they swung into the room and back toward the beds. She had turned to face him but he spun her around and pushed her onto the bed on her stomach.

Maybe he could be our bull, if you don't mind.

He pushed her skirt up, revealing her small, smooth bottom and the enticing black panties nestled in her crack. He could smell her scent, strong and tangy, from where he was, hovering above her and admiring the view.

She started to reach behind her to pull on the panties, but he climbed onto his knees and stopped her hand by grabbing her wrist. With his free hand, he hooked his fingers under the panties and slid down, the material turning wet the further his fingers traveled. He peeled it away from her skin and then jerked it to the side so that he could see her swollen, glistening pussy.

"So it really turns you on, thinking about our neighbor," he observed.

Raine turned her head in alarm, her brown hair flying, damp at the tips with her sweat. "I don't – I didn't –" she started to protest.

He pulled on her underwear, this time letting the fabric cut into her pussy and rub over her clit. He pulled hard, making her gasp. "I said, you like that, don't you, thinking about our neighbor."

He said it as a statement, more like he was telling her what she liked, and what she wanted.

She gasped as he tugged hard on her panties.

"Yes," she said.

“Say it.”

“I like thinking about him,” she said.

He tugged on her panties and the fabric began to shred.

“You like thinking about his big, black cock?”

His own cock was throbbing, dripping cum into his underwear and making a stain even on his pants. “Say it,” he urged her, the booze making him take a wild risk. “You like thinking about his big thick cock.”

Raine turned her face to the mattress and moaned. “I like it,” she said.

He ripped the panties away from her and pushed her legs apart. Her cunt was pink, eraser-colored like her nipples, and it shone with her sticky juices. Her clit was so swollen it peeked out from between her folds. He ran his fingers over the sensitive contours of her flesh, the ridges and hills of throbbing pink, making her gasp as he flitted over the most sensitive parts.

Did he say it aloud as he filled her pussy with his cock? Or did he only imagine that he did? Or was he only hoping that his wife's pussy clenched his cock harder and quivered around his shaft, quickly tensing toward a climax that shook her whole body, because he told her to imagine the neighbor's huge black shaft filling her and stretching her tight little hole?

Later he wouldn't remember if he actually said that, but he was sure that Raine's fingers dug into the mattress as she bucked wildly against him, slamming her ass against his hips and yelping until she was screaming, which was something she hadn't done for a long, long time.

After she came, he sawed gently in the quivering liquid of her cunt as she lay sweaty and limp, her ass pointed up submissively for him. He was sure then that she was imagining Gabe, pounding away into her used hole, until he filled her full of his hot cum.

He tried to make it last longer, but the thought of his wife betraying him in her thoughts as she lay there getting fucked was as stimulating as the thought of her being fucked senseless by a thick black cock, so it wasn't long before he groaned and dumped his seed inside of her.

He held on to her hips as the last spurts of his cum drained into her sloshing pussy, and then he bent over her, pulling her to him so that her sweaty back pressed against his chest. Her skin had cooled lightly in the frigid air of the hotel room, and his hardened nipples electrified upon contact with her wet flesh. His cock was still semi-hard inside of her, and it

pulsed against the soft walls of her channel before flopping out with a filthy slurp.

He kept her close to him as he lay down on his side and they spooned. “Wow,” he said. “That was... really hot.”

Her body moved a little, up and down in a quick motion from the depths of her chest. At first he wasn't sure if she was crying or coughing, or what, but he heard the familiar sniff of a characteristic laugh of hers, one that she only used when she wasn't quite sure what else to do.

He pushed her hair away from her neck; beneath the silky mane, the wispy fine hairs close to her neck were soaked. “You okay?” he said, with his lips close to her neck.

She murmured something, and he could tell she was drowsy. He wanted to talk about what had happened, but he realized they were probably both too drunk to have the sort of conversation he wanted to have.

He lay there, unable to stop thinking about what it would be like to hold his wife like this, after fucking her stretched and used pussy, after adding his own cum to her overflowing cunt. What would it be like to watch Gabe do what he had just done, then to feel the insides of her pussy with his own cock – feel that Gabe's thickness had already pushed her open, that Gabe's seed had already soaked into her, that she had already come again and again underneath Gabe's body?

While he was thinking about all of this, his cock got hard again. He worked his fingers beneath Raine's thigh, lifting it slightly, pushing and pulling her into position so that he could slip into her slick folds again.

Raine made a sleepy, sexy noise, and did not squirm away from him as he filled her again. He put his fingers into her hair and gripped it, pushing her forward slightly so that her ass tilted against him. He began slowly, almost tenderly, as though she had actually just come back from being pounded hard by Gabe, as though his every thrust would inflame her raw pussy.

But the more he thought of her squirming because her cunt was sore from being abused mercilessly by the neighbor, the harder he wanted to fuck her, and so he grasped her hips and sawed into her. She may have been sleepily playing along for a bit, but she was the one who rolled onto her stomach and ground up against him, bucking wildly as he thrust deep into her until they came at the same time.

The same nervous laugh, and a shy smile. He rolled onto his side, facing her.

“Wow,” she said drowsily, and smiled again.

But her eyelids were heavy, and they fell closed. He touched her cheek with his fingers, and her mouth turned up in the same smile, but only got halfway before it sort of faded away into a pleasant, neutral expression, and it was clear she was asleep.

His own eyelids grew heavy, and he was also asleep before he knew it.

CHAPTER 6

Columbus had been a relief for Raine in a lot of ways: she was convinced, after they returned home, that Michael was not having an affair, and that was something that she hadn't realized had been bothering her as much as it had. Now that it had been lifted from her shoulders, she realized what a weight it had been.

And Columbus had been fun, there was no doubt about that.

But, as she usually did when she had fun and then sobered up, Raine started brewing and letting clouds of doubt and guilt come rolling in and rain on her. First, there was the matter of all the drinking, which she rarely did and regretted for both the caloric content and the way she had behaved.

And then there was the uneasy feeling that the whole night had left her with. The thoughts it had put in her head, and the way she could not stop returning to them.

She didn't know if what had transpired between her and Michael had been pure fantasy, or if there had been some element of truth to it. She couldn't read Michael, or how serious he was, and while she knew that the easiest thing to do would be to just ask him, point blank, she felt like this was as difficult of a task as asking him, point-blank, if he was having an affair.

That was probably because she didn't know what she would do with the answer, whatever it was; nor was she sure what her response would be, if Michael asked the same question of her.

She was thinking about all of this in the afternoon about a week later, staring at the stream of hot water pouring into the oversized bathtub in their upstairs bathroom. The bathroom was her favorite part of the house: it had a large arched window that looked out over the lawn, and windows all around that she pulled the blinds up on (once she was in the tub). If she sank down to where her chin was just above the water, it looked like she was taking a bath in a forest in the country, which was something she figured almost anyone would enjoy pretending when in fact they lived in Cleveland.

Today, though, she was so preoccupied with her thoughts about her neighbor, and her husband, and her husband's thoughts about her neighbor,

that she let the tub overflow. She turned the faucet with her foot and sighed, annoyed that she would have to listen to the drain dribble away for ten minutes with the overflow. Also, because the tub was so big and the water heater so old, that she had now run out of hot water. Raine liked her baths to scald, even in summer, and this one was a degree or two too cool, and getting cooler by the minute.

She sat up and reached for the cord to open the blinds. She rested on her arm and tugged slowly, still deep in thought. The blinds were only partway up when the dark, muscular arms of her neighbor caught her eye. She paused, left the blinds open just a few inches, and pulled back into the darkness of her home to watch him as he sat down in his deck chair and opened his laptop.

There was nothing to see, really: just a great-looking man she couldn't even see in detail, sitting at a table and typing on a computer.

But she couldn't tear her eyes away from him.

She didn't think that Michael could possibly be serious. What kind of man would want to see his wife have sex with another man?

Just the thought of it, materializing in her mind as only words and not even an image, made her queasy. She didn't like to admit it to herself, but the feeling was a good one. Her chest felt tight and she took a deep breath.

His thighs were like tree trunks, she found herself thinking involuntarily. He sat with his legs open, even out there by himself. It wasn't so much his sheer size, or the way muscle was packed onto every square inch of his body in sinewy lines. It wasn't just the baritone voice or the steady, alpha demeanor in his every action, exuding the sort of confidence she had never known any man to have.

It was also – and she kept this secret almost to herself – that he was so dark, so exotic, so... untasted.

She sat back in the tub and tore her eyes away from the window.

She was a happily married woman. She knew better than to even *think* about any of this. She should stop right now. After all, she *loved* Michael, and that was absolutely true. She would never want anything bad to happen to their relationship; she realized that now that she felt the relief of him not having an affair.

Still... what if? What if Michael *had* been serious about what he was saying?

She shifted in the tub and looked out the window again.

There wasn't any harm in thinking about something, was there? No harm in just *contemplating* another man. After all, Michael had to be looking at porn once in a while, right? What was wrong with her imagining what was underneath their neighbor's clothing? Or what it would look like if he were standing in front of her, undressed, all of his muscles highlighted by the light?

She worked her fingers down to her pussy, and slipped them into the wet, slimy folds. She couldn't remember being this spontaneously turned on before. Not as often, or as quickly, not just from a *thought*.

She closed her eyes and began to rub the face of her clit. And for some reason, as she brought herself quickly to climax, she envisioned something she almost never gave much thought at all, especially not when she was masturbating: she imagined what it would be like to get on her knees and open her mouth wide for Gabe-the-neighbor's big, black cock, to feel him all the way at the back of her throat, the pressure of his hand on the back of her head. She could almost feel herself gagging as he bumped the back of her palate with the fat domed head of his dick, her cheeks and her jaw getting sore as they stretched wide, her eyes watering and open in submission.

But not looking at Gabe: looking right at her husband, with a mouthful of cock.

The guilt began to wash over her in waves, as the pleasure of her orgasm receded.

What was she doing?

Her cheeks grew hot, as though someone were watching her. Judging her. As though someone could see inside her mind and access all of the filthy thoughts she was having about her neighbor.

She dared to look out the window again.

She drew back immediately with a gasp, because Gabe was looking right up at the window, right at her.

Her chest grew tight and she sank down into the tub, breathing heavily. Her whole torso was cold with the wild feeling of getting caught.

She didn't dare move. The water was getting cold and she felt paralyzed.

Finally, she sat up.

“He’s not looking at you,” she said. How could he be? The blinds were only partially drawn and no one could see into a house at this time of day more than a few inches anyway. He couldn’t have seen her face. And even if he did, he was the one who should feel bad. He was the voyeur.

But he had probably just been looking around, the way anyone does, at the houses around him. Probably he had been looking not at her window, or her, but at a gutter or something.

Raine knew she was right. She also still felt guilty.

Also, who was she kidding? She was a plain, skinny girl with hardly any chest or bottom. She had brown hair, she was not exactly anyone’s dream girl. Why would a guy like that be even remotely interested in her?

Raine was the kind of woman who took showers at the gym with reluctance, and always as privately as possible, and only because she felt like she was old enough by now to be mature enough to shower in front of other women without feeling weird.

So it shocked the hell out of her – as it would out of anyone who knew her – when she pulled suddenly on the blinds to raise them. She stared straight ahead at the faucet, breathing without thinking, driven by something she couldn’t quite describe to herself.

And then, without looking to the side, she rose from the water. Creamy white bubbles clung to her, but not in any of the right places. She kept her eyes off the window, reached for a towel, and began to dry herself off while still standing in the center of the tub. She was at a distance from the window that she did not know whether she could be seen from outside or not.

She didn’t even know if her neighbor was still looking.

And she wouldn’t.

She dried off, rubbing the towel over her body like a dishrag so that she didn’t cover herself up, stepped out of the tub, and walked into the bedroom.

She sat on the edge of the bed, her ears so full of her own blood that she could hear her heartbeat in them.

“What was that?” she asked herself aloud.

And then she felt the red flush creeping over her cheeks.

But this time, the flush had a different quality to it. Small amounts of it were due to something other than embarrassment, and deep down inside,

she knew it.

CHAPTER 7

“What did you do all day today, with your day off?” Michael asked, kissing Raine on the forehead. She was folded onto the couch with a laptop in front of her and her face was contorted by the frown she reserved specifically for accounting courses, so it was obvious what she had been doing all day.

“Mmm,” she mumbled, chewing on a pencil. “Just let me solve this problem...”

Michael took in his wife’s appearance while he set his briefcase down on the dining room table. She was wearing that denim-colored blue dress he liked so much, again without a bra. Cross-legged as she was on the couch, he had a nice view of her underwear.

She slammed the laptop shut suddenly. “I hate this class,” she said. She jumped up from the couch and kissed Michael on her way to the kitchen. “I’ve been studying all day, I can’t get things right, let’s go out to eat or something...” Her voice trailed off as she stood by the kitchen sink with a glass in her hand.

For a moment she was so preoccupied with what she was seeing that she poured the water into the sink just next to the glass.

“Oh my God,” she said. “Oh. My. God.”

“What?” Michael said, because the sound of alarm was real in her voice and she made it sound like something was on fire outside.

She whirled around to face him. “He’s coming over here.”

Michael was walking toward the window, but he knew as soon as she said it who “he” was. Still, he approached the window and looked out, if nothing more to confirm for himself that the tall black man they had rented their house to was, in fact, crossing the lawn and heading toward their house.

“What is he...?” Raine said, bewildered.

They watched as Gabe walked straight into the yard, skirted along the side of the house, and disappeared from view.

They looked at each other.

“What was tha-” Raine began.

The doorbell rang.

Again, they exchanged glances, and Michael had little time to wonder about Raine's expression before they began walking to the front door together. She seemed unduly out of sorts, given what was happening. She shook her hands by her sides as she walked toward the door, almost as if she were approaching a confrontation.

"He could be a Jehovah's Witness," Michael said, to lighten the mood.

Raine looked back at him before she opened the door, as though she needed help with something. She looked guilty. He wondered if she still had any lingering guilt about their fantastic night at the hotel, which was too bad but pretty hot at the same time. He willed himself not to get an erection about it, and was only moderately effective.

"Oh," Raine said, as though she were completely surprised to see Gabe on her doorstep. "Uh, Gabe." She popped her head out of the door frame, like she wanted to look for more people. "How are you?"

Michael felt his insides twist as she spoke to him. She was using the kind of voice that people usually used for lying, and he enjoyed a fun little fantasy in which she was having an affair with Gabe and was now worried that maybe he had come to tell her husband the truth, or something that would uncover her lies.

"Hi," Gabe said. His eyes took another leisurely walk all over Raine's body, lingering at the deep plunge between her breasts. His big hands were intertwined and he pulled his fingers apart and then pushed them back together several times before saying, "Nice dress."

His eyes took on Michael immediately, and he added, as though he had never said anything about Raine's dress: "Sorry to bother y'all, but I'm having a party later on and I thought I'd let you know." He looked at Raine. "Just in case you were trying to relax in the tub or something, it might get a little loud."

Raine flushed at his bathtub comment, her mind flashing back to the afternoon, wondering whether he was telling her, oh-so-subtly, that he had been watching her earlier, but she said nothing. Clearly oblivious to the potential sub-text, Michael had no idea what to say, either.

"Anyway, I always just invite all the neighbors over when I have a party. I find most people won't call the cops on a party they're at. So...

anytime once it gets started, come on over if you like.”

There was a long and awkward pause, while Gabe stood smiling at Raine, and Raine stood with her mouth slightly open, saying nothing.

“Did you invite Marilyn?” Michael said, to break the strange mood up.

Marilyn lived next door to Raine and Michael and was directly behind Gabe’s house. The question was a joke because she was about ninety.

“I’d love it,” Gabe said, without missing a beat, “if Marilyn would come, but she said she goes to bed at eight so she may miss the best parts. Anyway, y’all are welcome, I have liquor and mixers but you have to bring your own beer if that’s your thing.”

Raine was still staring. She pushed a strand of hair out of her face. “Um... what kind of party is it?” she said softly.

Gabe bestowed a smile on her. “Just a party, little thing. No voodoo, no rappers, no strippers, if that’s what you’re worried about.”

Raine scratched her neck. “No, not... I just meant, what should we... wear...?”

Another smile. “That dress is just fine,” Gabe said. He smacked his fist into his palm and snapped his fingers. “Well. Gotta run. Hope you can make it.”

They closed the door after saying “bye” in what Michael felt was the whitest way possible.

Raine was still holding onto the door handle.

“Uh...” Raine said. She looked at him. “That was crazy.”

If by crazy she meant “crazy hot,” he was inclined to agree with her. Michael was still hearing him call her “little thing,” replaying the flirtatious way he had told her that her dress was “fine,” and another part of his mind was quickly assembling a montage of filthy, fantasy images for him.

“We should go,” he suggested cheerfully.

Raine looked at him, alarmed. “What?”

He shrugged. “What else are we doing tonight? Could be fun.”

Raine smiled at one corner of her mouth and then looked worried. “I don’t know...” she said. “I don’t think he really wants us there, he’s just being polite.”

Michael rolled his eyes. “Well, he definitely wants *you* there. But maybe not me. Anyway... let’s have some drinks and loosen up, and then

just go check it out. We can watch it from here and if it seems lame -”

“Or crazy,” she said.

“Or... crazy... then we’ll stay home. Okay?”

Raine looked down at her dress. “I’m definitely not wearing this,” she said.

Michael cocked his head. “Why not? Wear it. It looks good on you.”

Gabe likes it, Michael thought.

And Michael likes it, too.

Michael also liked the idea of her wearing it at a party. Seeing everyone’s eyes on her.

“Come on,” he said, when Raine didn’t say anything. “Have a drink, we’ll think about it.”

*

They had a few drinks and no dinner and moved out to the screened-in porch to contemplate the party as it got going down the slope, in their neighbor’s backyard.

“It just seems like a normal party,” Raine commented. Her feet were up on the table, and the skirt had slumped around her hips. Her legs were firm and freshly shaved, and she looked particularly beautiful in the evening light. “Maybe we should pop by.”

Michael took another swig of his beer. “Be neighborly,” he said.

This made Raine – who was quite loosened up by the booze – laugh lightly.

“Okay, well, let’s go then,” Michael said. “You’re wearing that dress, right?”

Raine tipped her head back. “No way,” she said. “Anyway I have to... I don’t know. Put some makeup on.”

“Wear the dress,” he suggested, with a slur in his voice. “It looks hot.”

Raine usually would have laughed it off and gotten up to change her dress immediately, but she looked straight ahead, down the slope, to Gabe’s house instead, and said nothing. “Well,” she said finally, shrugging. “I do hate going up and down the stairs.”

Michael hadn’t expected that. His chest felt tight.

He decided to get her out the door before she changed her mind. “Okay,” he said. “Well... should we go, then?”

He watched his wife’s reaction carefully. She gave another thoughtful pause before turning to him. She was leaning on the lawn chair, her head propped on the back of it, her hair spread out behind her. “It could be fun,” she said, almost as a question.

It was a loaded statement, at least in Michael’s mind. He wondered if they were thinking the same subtext, or if it was only him who was thinking they were talking about something other than merely going to the party.

“Could be,” he said.

She turned back toward the yard. “Could be a disaster, though.”

His heart was thumping loudly in his chest. He wasn’t sure what to do: if they *were* really talking about the same thing, he wasn’t sure he really wanted to open that Pandora’s Box *really*. After all, if they *were* actually talking about – he shivered – Raine flirting with, or even doing more with their neighbor, then this was the kind of thing they couldn’t walk back. Ever. If Raine were to sleep with another man, especially this man, it would change everything about their marriage forever.

“Okay,” Raine said suddenly. She stood up, slamming the wine glass on the table loudly. She was pretty drunk, he could see. “Let’s just go. If it sucks we can come back.”

“Okay!” he said enthusiastically.

Raine was probably only talking about the party, with no subtext. After all, a party, you could come back from.

*

There were about ten people out on the deck and a handful of people inside the house. They were all more or less in their thirties, more or less attractive, and more or less normal-looking. No one gave them any shady looks when they approached, and Raine shyly said “hi” to a few of them as they made their way up the deck and into the house.

Michael was armed with some beers, which he didn’t feel like drinking, but had correctly guessed were a good way to look like he had some business being there. With beers in hand, you have all kinds of easy

ice-breaker questions to ask like, “Want a beer?” or “Where can I put these?”

Raine was being unusual, he decided, watching her as she hopped up the stairs ahead of him. She usually trailed behind, not really one to venture into a crowd. But now she was ahead of him, almost like she was looking to dive into the party or... find someone.

“Where can I put these?” he asked a guy who opened the screen door for them.

“Got a cooler out here,” he answered, and shut the screen door to show Michael to it, with Raine inside. And that was how Michael lost track of his wife right from the beginning.

He ended up chatting with a few people on the deck, all the while wondering what was transpiring in the house. His blood pressure was rising; he could barely concentrate on what was being said to him, which was fine, because almost 90% of human interaction had always seemed like an exchange of nonsense to him. Especially if you weren’t even trying to hook up with someone.

That might have been what was so exciting about Raine being inside Gabe’s house. Gabe the good-looking black man, Gabe who might steal her away. He might have to get her back, which gave him a particularly strange thrill.

He was thinking about going inside to find her, thinking about all the ways the evening could play out, when he felt his phone buzzing against his thigh. He had tucked it into the cargo pants he’d changed into before coming over.

And wouldn’t you know it? It was a client.

“Roger,” he said, glancing toward the door. “I’m just at a party. Give me two minutes and I’ll call you back from a quieter place.”

He didn’t even wait for Roger to agree. He moved quickly into the house, noticing the rich interior, the expensive furniture, how extremely clean it was – and located Raine at the breakfast bar, which was being used as a real bar, with Gabe behind it like a bartender.

He leaned down to her ear, without greeting Gabe first, and whispered: “Roger’s calling, I have to go back up to the house for a bit.”

He was soaring on a high. He was excited to leave his wife here, to see what would happen. “Don’t do anything I wouldn’t do,” he said, and on

his chin he felt the pimpled gooseflesh his words inspired on Raine's neck.

Satisfied that he was setting up something exciting, he gave Gabe a nod as he turned to head back to the house. "Sorry man," he said. "Gotta take this call."

"Wait, when will you be back?" Raine said, holding her arms open wide as though she were thoroughly confused and shocked that he would leave her there.

But that was tricky of her, Michael thought, because Raine was often left at parties and dinners and all sorts of other functions for a client call. She was acting, and he wasn't sure who the act was for.

He smiled. "Not sure, I'll send you a text. Have fun. I'll try to be quick."

And he hopped out the door, thoroughly pleased with what he had managed to set up, if only by happenstance. He was so pleased with himself that he almost forgot to call Roger back.

CHAPTER 8

Raine turned back to Gabe, who had his eyebrows raised in a sympathetic expression, mimicking hers. He poured her a martini and pushed it toward her by the base. “That happen a lot?” he asked.

Raine shrugged and picked an olive out of her glass. The truth was, she was excited by the prospect of being left here alone with Gabe. She wondered if Michael had done it on purpose. Her heart fluttered at the prospect.

“I would have a hard time leaving a hot little thing like you at a party all by yourself,” Gabe said.

Raine sipped her martini. Well, gulped it, to be exact.

“Never know who might snap you up,” Gabe said.

Raine swallowed a larger gulp, and set the glass down. The martini was more than half finished.

Gabe certainly didn’t waste any time. Her heart raced. It had been such a long time since someone had said anything like that to her. She had no idea how to react, so she wiped her lips delicately with a finger and nodded.

“That’s a hot dress,” Gabe said. “You don’t usually dress like that.”

Raine was genuinely surprised. “I don’t... what? How would you know that?”

Gabe shrugged, and said nothing for a while. While he looked at her, she remembered the way he had referred to her taking a bath when he had asked her over, and she wondered if he had seen her that afternoon. The memory of what she had done – and how bold it was – made her inside blush, though she felt confident that she had enough actual blush on to cover anything the rapidly heating flush was doing to her face. Or at least she hoped so.

“I keep an eye on things,” Gabe said plainly.

Raine’s insides burned. She had never met a man this forward before in her life.

She was grateful when a few guys came up to the counter and started talking to Gabe, asking him for a drink, and shooting the shit. Raine took

the opportunity to start edging away, hoping to slide right off the end of the counter with her drink, head into the night air, and get out of there before she did any one of the things she was actually worried about herself doing.

“Hey hey, where you goin’?” Gabe said. “Brad, Kris, this is Raine. Short for Lorraine,” he added.

Raine smiled at them.

“I’m not done talking to you,” Gabe said, and her chest burned from the inside.

“Lorraine,” one of them said. “That’s such a fifties’ secretary name. It’s cool,” he added quickly.

“Why didn’t you go with Lo?” the other one asked.

Gabe shook the martini shaker violently. “Don’t be askin’ her no dumb questions,” he said, breaking into a heretofore unheard black vernacular. “Why you go by Brad instead of Bra?”

They lingered a while, talking about sports and cars, and Raine finished her martini. Gabe poured her another one without asking her, and she sipped on that, wondering how she could get out of there. It was a bad idea to stay there, a bad idea to get drunk, a bad idea all around.

But by the time she reached the bottom of her martini, she had a different attitude. Gabe was smiling at her, making her stomach twist. She hadn’t done anything, after all, just gone over to a party. They were practically in public. They weren’t even touching. And anyway, Michael was the one who’d left her here with him.

He could have asked her to go home.

It wasn’t as if he hadn’t practically given her permission to do this very thing.

Gabe was looking at the open fold of her dress, where it criss-crossed to (barely) cover her breasts. While he was looking away she looked down to check and make sure it was a good view. She jumped a little when she realized that he could probably see right down her shirt when she leaned forward.

She sat up, bringing the material to close up around the curve of her breasts.

The two guys left without saying goodbye, a few more people asked for drinks, and the volume of the party seemed to increase in three solid stages. Whoomp, whoomp, whoomp.

Raine looked around. "Some party," she said.

Gabe shrugged. He looked back at her chest. "Too bad, you ruined my view," he said.

There was no way to take that except for what it was.

And then Raine found herself – probably because she was drunk – doing a terrible thing.

She leaned forward again. She could feel the material pull away from her chest, sag in front of her, cool air kissing her slightly sweaty skin. Her nipples tightened into little balls, and she knew he could see them.

"That's more like it," he said.

Was she actually doing this? Letting a stranger look down her shirt?

But she didn't stop there.

"So," she said. She almost couldn't believe the next words even as she formed them with her own mouth. "I have a confession to make."

Just saying it made her go cold and feel a little shaky. What the hell was she doing?

But there was nothing to stop her now. Michael had basically given it his blessing, and anyway he wasn't even here. Gabe was coming after her, looking at her like he was stalking her. And her underwear was soaked just from thinking about thinking about her dirty, wild fantasies.

Gabe put his lips together and poured another martini into her glass.

"Oh, I shouldn't," she said, but she knew she was going to.

"Martinis go well with confessions," Gabe said smoothly. "So what have you done? Run over a bunny or something?"

Raine bit into an olive. She looked offended. "Why do you say that?" she asked.

Gabe chuckled. "You just don't seem like the type to make a serious confession. If I have you pegged right."

He was looking at her like a wolf about to chase after a meal. Raine's whole body was tingling. She told herself again that she needed to get up, get off the stool, and go home. She was drunk, she was *pretty* sure that Gabe was flirting with her in a really serious way, and what was worse, she was really enjoying it.

"I do bad things sometimes," she said. She twisted the olives in the martini.

Gabe wiped his hands on his jeans and leaned on the counter. "Oh, I have no doubt of that," he said, and his deep voice rumbled right through her and made her tremble with pleasure. "So tell me, what bad thing did you do?"

Her chest squeezed so hard her breath came right out of her.

"Well," she said.

She was torn between telling him that she had stood up in the bathroom to let him see her, deliberately. Or telling him the other thing. That she knew. She knew he was a bull and she wanted him to be hers.

Her veins burned with excitement.

"So... you have to promise not to get mad," she said, her voice shaking.

Gabe dropped onto his elbow. "Mmm. It gets juicier."

"I probably shouldn't tell you," she said.

"I hope you will," he countered, and his eyes went up and down her body again. The glance was so charged she felt it on her skin. He sucked on his lower lip. "Finish that martini, if you need to."

She took a long drink of the martini.

"Okay," she said, gathering courage all at once. "I was in Columbus last week and I saw you," she lied. She decided, on the fly, to keep Michael out of it. She wasn't sure why; maybe to have a way to back out of what was brewing here. After all, she *was* married. She could still fall back on that to get herself out of here. She leaned back. "At least I think it was you."

He stood up. "Now *that*," he said, still glazing her with the bask of his sexual glower, "I find hard to believe."

She felt caught out suddenly, and her face went red. The idea that Michael hadn't actually seen Gabe had never even occurred to her. But that could easily have happened. *She* had never seen him.

Oh God, she thought. What if this whole thing was just a wild, terrible mix-up?

"Maybe it wasn't you," she said quickly. "That..uh... that explains it."

"I just find it hard to believe," he said, leaning back on his elbows.

"That you saw me and I didn't see you."

He bored a hole right through her as he stared at her.

"I was in Columbus last week. So you could have seen me." He paused, letting the air between them simmer some more. "But that isn't

really a confession, is it?”

His voice seemed to Raine to be getting lower and lower, and more hypnotic. She looked down at her hands to make sure they weren't really in his, because she felt like they were. She was imagining his hands on hers, and her body, in such vivid detail that it almost felt real.

“So what is it you saw me doing in Columbus, Raine?”

Raine tapped her martini glass and thought for a moment.

Oh, screw it, she thought. And then suddenly she was talking.

“Okay,” she said. “So I saw... you were at the Hyatt downtown and I think I saw... I'm pretty sure that I saw you with, um, a woman, and... so she was like, with this other guy, too.”

Raine felt a rush as she got the whole story out of her mouth. Once she did, it didn't seem so bad, it actually seemed kind of fun. She looked up and met Gabe's eyes, which were twinkling.

“Blonde lady? Tall? Leggy?”

She nodded, even though she didn't know. She still wanted, for some reason, to leave Michael – and his implicit approval of what she was doing here – out of the story.

“You wondering what all that was about?” Gabe said, like he already knew the answer.

On the countertop, his fingertips were getting closer, and now they brushed the tips – just the very tips – of her fingers. The sensation was close to orgasmic. Her eyelids felt heavy, and if she had been standing, she might have buckled at the knees.

She watched his fingers as they started to travel along the length of her middle finger.

He adjusted himself on his elbows, his fingers traveling along her arm, stopping to make a circle in the crook of her elbow. Raine almost gasped; she had no idea how this guy was managing to create a direct line between her elbow and her pussy, but he had done it. She throbbed between her legs.

He was very close to her now. Anyone watching would have viewed them as a couple about to go upstairs and go to bed.

“What is it *you* think you saw?” he asked.

Raine swallowed. She didn't dare take her eyes away from his, but she really wanted to look around the room and see if anyone was watching

them. After all, didn't everyone know she was married? Hadn't they seen her come with her husband? They would know she was a cheating slut.

Her throat felt like it had a lump in it.

She shook her head. "I don't -" she started to say, but her throat was dry and her voice was hoarse. "I don't know."

Gabe's fingertips had reached her torso now, were right against her sternum. They were pulling the material of her dress, tugging downward, bunching the fabric in between them, exposing her skin. She could feel the harder edge of the neckline sliding along the curve of her breast, dangerously close to her nipple. It would pop out any moment.

He stopped, just before it did, and moved his thumb over the fabric and over her nipple. All the while, he held her captive with his dark brown eyes. He licked his lips, a quick side-to-side motion that she had seen a lot of black men do.

"I think you know exactly what you saw," he said.

Craving, cold and delicious, pooled just beneath her pelvic bone and she could actually feel her panties getting wet. "And I think," he added, "you might want to do more than just see it."

Another group of party-goers showed up at the counter at that moment, but they made their way behind the bar and asked Gabe if he had any mint and then started taking over the mixing of drinks. Gabe moved slowly from the other side of the bar toward Raine, and her whole body felt like it was on fire.

As he walked behind her, he put his hand over her throat. He did it so quickly, so gently, she almost couldn't believe that it had happened. And yet the touch of his hand on her throat, the strength behind its gentleness, left her skin damp and tingling.

He sat down next to her. They were facing the kitchen, not each other, and he was just a hair width away from her. She could feel the heat of his skin even though he wasn't touching her.

"Your hubby coming back?" he asked. "Is he the kind that wants to watch?"

Raine looked down at her hands. She was suddenly overwhelmed. "I don't... he... I don't know if he... this isn't, um, like some regular thing, or anything, like, we're not swingers, or anything like that."

She looked at him shyly.

“Oh, I know,” he said. “This is your first time.”

Raine was so stunned her eyes felt like they would water up.

His hand was on her knee. “I’ll be gentle.”

His palm covered her entire thigh at the knee, so his fingers were deep on the inside of it. He used them to pry her legs apart a little by spreading his hand open, and then he drew his whole hand up her thigh, pushing the dress up with it. His pinky finger wriggled against her damp underwear when he reached her pussy, and he squeezed her thigh muscle gently but firmly in his hand as he played with her swollen clit through the fabric of her panties.

Raine was paralyzed. Her muscles went stiff: here she was in a pretty much public setting, people all around, and a man who was not her husband had his hand up her skirt.

And she wasn’t doing a damn thing about it.

And it felt *good*. She knew she should tell him to stop, but she really didn’t want to.

He rubbed her clit, working her up, and she started to feel like she might boil over, right there in front of all the people at this party, right in this house, just a hundred yards from her own home. Her skin was hot, she could feel an orgasm taking over, and she shifted, just a little, to get his fingers pressed against her more firmly. The insides of her pussy throbbed, craving his fingers inside of her.

Or his cock.

And then, just as surprisingly as the whole thing had begun, his fingers withdrew from beneath her panties and the underwear shifted back into place with a soft snap.

Gabe leaned in close to her, and his breath was warm and brushed over the fine hairs on her neck to send a shiver through her core. The edges of her ears burned to feel his dry, warm lips on them.

She turned her face toward Gabe. Desire was pounding inside of her, and she felt like her self-control was slipping. She would have done almost anything to get his fingers back beneath her dress. “I, uh, he is. We talked about it. Pretty much.”

She realized that she sounded almost desperate, and the feeling didn’t sit well with her but her blood was pounding in her ears and she was dizzy.

In all her life she had never felt so compulsive about sex, like she would do such bad things to get it. Her head was spinning.

Gabe tilted his chin and moved his gaze from Raine to something behind her shoulder. "Sometimes guys think it's more fun if there's *no* agreement, if you know what I mean," he said. "But I don't need my landlord having some problem with me, either. As a rule, I don't get involved in this kind of situation."

He stood up and went back behind the bar, and her heart plummeted.

Raine was suddenly chilled: he had made her sweat, and now that the heat of his body was no longer next to her, the air conditioning was eating her wet flesh.

Gabe poured her another martini, which she felt she shouldn't probably drink, but he pushed it toward her and she didn't really know how to decline it. Her body still radiated with the heat of his touch.

"I don't know, though," he said, and Raine struggled to remember what he was talking about. "In your case, I might make an exception."

Raine sipped on the martini because she didn't really know what else to do. Her hand was shaking and she hoped he didn't notice.

She was grateful when a group of people clustered at the bar and asked Gabe to make them drinks. "Sure thing," he said, and he started to make them, but he didn't stop looking at Raine. Every time he met her eyes, she felt her chest tighten and her stomach drop through her core. She was getting wet just having this man look at her.

When she turned to look out the large window to her right, from the kitchen overlooking the yard, she had the heart-stopping slam of fear that she usually got from someone jumping out of a closet in a horror movie.

Michael was standing in the yard, looking through the window. He was stone-faced, maybe even pale.

The martini shook in her hand and she set it down to steady herself. Her heart was hammering inside her chest.

Michael had a six-pack of beer in his hand, and he started to walk into the house.

Raine stood up. "Excuse me," she said hoarsely.

Gabe, if he was confused, did not show it at all. He smiled at her, and went back to making his drinks. Michael was entering through the sliding doors when she faced them. She took an unsteady step, her mind whirling,

feeling as though she had been stripped naked in front of the entire party. How many people had witnessed her just now? And was Michael one of them?

Her thighs were wet and slippery against each other as she followed Michael over to the couch, holding her martini as steadily as she could, her heart sinking through her feet and a cold anesthesia taking over her limbs.

Even while her pussy throbbed.

CHAPTER 9

The phone call hadn't taken very long, but then, he hadn't really expected it to.

He sat down on the porch and watched Gabe's house with a beer in his hand.

At first, he told himself he was only waiting to go back because he wasn't a very sociable person. But this was a lie and not one that he could convince himself of.

What he was really doing, he knew, was leaving his wife with Gabe, to see what would happen. And secretly, he was hoping that something *would* happen. Electrical rivers were coursing up and down the center of his torso, and his erection was swelling as he thought about all the delicious possibilities of his wife doing something very, very bad down there with Gabe.

Or even if she was just sitting there, like a sitting duck, in that blue dress. Even if all that was happening was that Gabe was enjoying the small point of her nipples through the fabric, or imagining what her tits looked like when they were bare and rocking slightly as she was fucked.

Because at the end of the day, Raine was not the type for anything more than fantasy.

Whatever he had gotten her to do at the hotel, however much she played into the game they were playing, at the end of the day she was a conservative little number, and she would never do anything more than flirt with this sort of thing.

Which was disappointing in some ways, but sort of a relief in others.

Michael grew bored as the light waned and he was unable to see anything at all that was going on down the slope. The mosquitoes were coming out and nearly everyone at the party had moved inside. Their voices were getting louder, everyone was drunker. He might as well go have a good time.

He slipped on the grass as he headed down the hill, which was the first clue that he was more inebriated than he thought he was.

He leaned behind him to see if he had a grass stain, and then picked up the spilled bottles of beer from the six-pack he had carried over.

When he looked up, he had a crystal-clear view right into the kitchen, and through the open archway over the counter, to where his wife was sitting.

Next to Gabe.

A picture can be deceiving, and it's true he couldn't see exactly what was happening between the two of them. Raine was staring straight ahead, and Gabe was looking in the same general direction. They were not speaking, and the party was going on around them as though they weren't there.

Gabe's muscled, tree-limb-sized arm was pressed against Raine's, crossing over slightly before disappearing below the counter. The muscles flexed ever so slightly, in a steady rhythm.

Like he was kneading something.

Michael felt sick, so much that he clutched his stomach.

His cock was painfully erect now, confusing the signals in his body with his roiling stomach.

Raine's lips were parted, her very doll-like face almost vacant.

And then, just like that, Gabe's hand was back above the table. He leaned toward Raine, and said something very close to her ear.

And his wife was left staring vacantly, her expression one of dissatisfaction.

A few seconds passed, Gabe standing near the counter top. He slid a martini toward Raine.

Michael's heart beat wildly, and his ears were ringing.

And then she turned, and met his stare.

The guilt on her face was obvious – maybe it wouldn't have been for anyone else who saw her. But Michael knew the perfect, compact curvature of her features, the way her eyes would get wide and doe-like if she thought she had done something wrong, the minute quiver at the edge of her mouth as her guilt dragged one corner down ever-so-slightly.

She had done it, he thought. The dirty little whore had sat there at the table letting Gabe the neighbor do *something* – and he was pretty sure he knew what – under the table to her.

She had actually done it.

His cock throbbed painfully. Ice-cold anger filled his veins, but even as it did, he had a talk with himself.

After all, hadn't he encouraged this very thing? Hadn't he deep down inside really wanted it?

Yes.

But he had believed that Raine would never do it.

Had he really wanted it? Had he really wanted his wife's sweet pink pussy spoiled by the fat fingers of this black man? Had he really wanted his wife to be capable of such a thing?

Even as he was thinking all of this, he was walking toward the sliding door. His grip on the beer was fierce and he had crushed the handle of the six-pack almost to oblivion.

As he escaped his wife's stare, walking toward the doors past a section of brick, the spell was broken.

Wait and see, he thought. Wait and see what Raine has to say.

They met each other's eyes as soon as he walked into the living room. The crowd was getting drunker; the music had stopped and no one seemed to care. A quick glance to the side revealed that Gabe was deep in an enthusiastic conversation about sports and disagreed strongly with whoever he was talking to.

Michael spotted a free couch (it was that time in the evening when people had begun disappearing into bedrooms or basements, or standing and shouting. There was a dangerous air of malevolence brewing).

They walked to the couch and sat down on it together.

He was sure that he could smell the tangy scent of her juices. His stomach lurched.

He put his hand on her knee, and he felt her shudder. He started to move it slowly up her leg, and she immediately became nervous. Her eyes jerked around the room, looking over at Gabe, and her face grew flushed. Finally, she put a hand on his and pressed it hard to her thigh.

Michael turned to look at her questioningly.

He liked what he saw: Raine was in a mood he had never seen her in. She was lusty, craving sex, and nervous, and guilty. Flustered almost beyond recognition.

He pushed his hand further up her leg.

“No one’s looking,” he said, as she pressed hard on his hand, but not hard enough to stop him.

When he reached her sticky thighs, he raised his eyebrows. “What have you been up to, Raine?” he asked.

She exhaled in reply. His fingers moved further up her leg, and she pulled the skirt over his hand because it had ridden all the way up her thigh. The material fell away almost immediately, and he smiled at her nonsensical attempt at modesty.

“Michael...” she said.

“Tell me what got you so worked up,” he countered. “And I’ll stop.”

Raine was quiet. He could feel her heartbeat, strong and fast, somewhere through her leg.

“So,” she said, finally. “I talked to him about.. you know.”

Michael’s body twitched.

Raine, having begun a confession, could not stop herself from confessing even more. The words began tumbling out of her mouth, each one of them pelting him like a sharp rock. “Well, I said, I told him *I* saw you, and he didn’t say anything. He didn’t seem too bothered by it. In fact... he seemed... interested.”

She looked at Michael then. He was stupefied, hanging on her every word.

“Interested,” he repeated, trying to move his hand further up her leg. She squeezed her thighs together and looked around the room.

“Interested, how?” he asked.

“Interested,” she said, and she looked at him. Her eyes burned right through his chest.

“And how do you know that?”

Raine’s legs trembled against his hand. “He uh, he said so, and then...”

Her voice faded away.

“Then what?”

Raine stared at the wall for a minute. He saw her eyes move, back to the kitchen. But Michael found he didn’t care so much if she saw Gabe or not, or if Gabe saw them. The only thing that interested him at this moment was whether or not his wife would cough up the truth about what had happened in the kitchen.

“He touched my fingers, like this.” She stroked his hand with her fingertips. The bulge in his pants twitched wildly. “And then he said, go make sure your man is okay with all of this.”

Her eyes were on his cock now.

She slid her hand down his thigh as she shifted and tucked her feet under her, forcing him to pull his hand from between her legs.

She had a gleam in her eyes now, and it made Michael’s heart beat faster with both betrayal and arousal. She was *never* like this. The front of her dress was open slightly, giving him a view into her dress, a hint of nipple, the shadows of her contoured breasts.

He realized she was very drunk. Ripe for bad decisions. Playful decisions. All kind of things. It was all so close, so within reach.

“He said.... he normally doesn’t do this with, you know, landlords. But he said for me...”

She let the unfinished sentence linger, and then she relished saying the next bit:

“..he said he’d make an exception.”

Michael’s breath was shaky as he exhaled.

“What, uh... what does that mean?” he asked.

She glanced over at the bar. Back to Michael.

“I guess, um... I guess it means... you know. *Doing it.*”

She had meant “doing it” as in “actually hotwifing,” as opposed to the game they were (sort of) playing at the moment. But she (and Michael, she could see by his face) immediately thought of the other meaning of “doing it;” the adolescent euphemism for “having sex.”

She covered her mouth and laughed. This made Michael laugh.

“I didn’t mean it that way,” she said, through her semi-hysterical breathing. “I just meant, you know, actually...”

“Doing it.”

She laughed again.

This went for a little bit, but slowly died down as they looked at each other, until it was suddenly very serious again.

“So,” Michael said, after clearing his throat and becoming quite somber. “Are you? Going to do it?”

Raine held his gaze.

“Do you want me to?” she asked.

Michael took her hand. "I want you to do what you want to do," he said. And then he remembered what he had seen, and it burned through his chest. "As long as you *always* tell me about it."

There was a long pause – he would remember it as an eternity. Raine's features contorted; he knew she was struggling with what she had just done, whatever that was.

"I have to tell you something," she said quietly.

He stared at her.

"I think we better go home," she added.

CHAPTER 10

Halfway back to their house she realized how drunk she was, and while she felt terrible about everything that had happened at Gabe's house, she decided she was doing the right thing by going home. Going home and confessing everything, and then never, ever stepping in these waters again.

Michael walked behind her, and she could feel him watching her. What was he feeling? How would he react when he found out that she had actually *done* what she had done?

It wasn't as if he hadn't implied that he wanted her to do it, right? She couldn't be blamed for that.

But she still felt incredibly guilty.

She pushed the door open and marched into the living room. It wasn't in her nature to be confrontational, or to head toward a problem, but her husband's words had chilled her: *as long as you always tell me about it*.

She didn't like any of this. She didn't like feeling out of control, or being controlled by carnal instincts. She didn't like risking her marriage. It had all seemed so fun just weeks ago; now it seemed too dangerous, too wild. She would confess to what had happened, hope that Michael could actually forgive her, and they would get on with their lives.

She whirled around. "Something happened over there," she said quickly, wanting to get it out before she had time to stop and think about the consequences or chicken out. "I don't... I don't know how it happened, but it did, and I wish I hadn't done it now."

Michael closed the door and stood by it. He was still in the kitchen. She couldn't get any sort of read on his face, whether he was angry, or turned on; disappointed or salaciously thrilled. Almost every one of those emotions seemed to play on his face.

He walked toward her, and for the first time ever in their marriage she sensed something almost menacing about how he was walking toward her.

But even more unimaginably, she was turned on by it.

"Did you do something bad, Raine?" he asked.

It was a hungry, sexually-laden question. There wasn't any doubt about that.

She felt the same paralysis that had overcome her at Gabe's house taking over her again. An inexplicable arousal, and at the same time a humiliating sense of guilt. The only problem was... the two sensations were combining together in a way that was... well, pleasurable.

"I don't know how it happened," she said.

Her husband, who had always been an attractive guy to her, of course, was moving toward her with a cat-like, prey-chasing energy. She wouldn't have gone so far as to say she liked it, but it was turning her on anyway. Her stomach felt like a jiggling bag of ice cubes, something she hadn't felt for so long she had almost forgotten how thrilling a sensation it was.

"And what is it that happened?" he said, close enough to touch her now.

She was searching for the right words to tell her husband of seven years that she had let their neighbor finger her in the middle of a party, that it had made her wet, that she had almost had an orgasm.

But she never got the chance, because he lunged toward her and pushed her backward, his hands yanking her dress up and her panties down. She fell onto the couch when her legs hit it, and Michael pushed her dress all the way up to her shoulders. The material fell over her head and entangled her arms, which he pushed up with one hand and suspended over her head on the back of the couch. His other hand found its way to her wet pussy and his fingers were inside of her in seconds.

"Does it have anything to do with how wet you are?" he growled.

Raine breathed heavily through the material of her dress. Her nipples were hard, and Michael's cotton shirt caressed them from time to time as he finger-fucked her. She pushed back against his fingers, her desires boiling up again, the peak of the pleasure he was giving her rising up toward her fast.

She had forgotten all of her guilt. The dress billowed from her face and then retreated, concave, into her mouth as she gasped.

"Well?" Michael said, pinching her clit with his ring finger and thumb. He curled the fingers embedded in her cunt outward, stroking her g-spot, making her wince in almost painful pleasure. She was getting so close...

And then he stopped. He waited while she squirmed, holding her hands above her head, her body impaled by his fingers.

“He just came around the table,” she said, realizing that he would never let her finish until she told him the truth. “And he put his... hand under my skirt.”

Michael began to move his fingers slowly in and out of her dripping pussy. He added a third and she gasped again. “And you just let him, didn’t you?”

Raine closed her eyes. The pleasure – the guilty, dirty pleasure of it was driving her wild.

“You just let him finger fuck you? Is that it? You little slut?”

Raine moaned as he clawed inside of her. She was so close...

Michael's fingers disappeared from inside of her and she mewled. The dress was suddenly pulled up and over her head. Michael was standing in front of her, taking off his shorts. He swung a hand down to her bottom, turning her over.

She put her hands on the back of the couch and tilted her ass up toward him, waiting for him to fill her from behind. She knew he was going to fuck her, and she could hardly wait to feel him inside of her, claiming her, teaching her a lesson, punishing her for being such a dirty slut.

His cock was rock solid, and he slid into her soaked folds like a knife in butter. And then he started to fuck her, hard. His cock pounded deeper inside of her than she thought he had ever been, his thighs slapping against her ass.

“Did he make you come?”

“No,” she said, her voice choking out as she gasped at the forceful thrust he drove deep inside of her. “No, he... he just...”

Michael pulled on her hair. “But you wish he did, don’t you? You wish he’d turned you around on his couch and fucked you full of his hot cum with his huge black cock, don’t you?”

Raine moaned again and gripped the back of the couch. She *did* wish that, she just couldn’t bring herself to say it. Michael’s cock was plunging in and out of her and her muscles started to seize as the high of a climax like none she had ever experienced in her life crested.

She lowered her head to the back of the couch and bit into the leather when she came. She was making a sound she knew she had never made before as her pussy spasmed around Michael’s cock. He was pounding her so hard that his cock was slamming into her cervix.

And though she would have denied it later, it was true: she was thinking about Gabe's cock, and what it would feel like if she ever gave herself over to him. How much it would fill her, and what it would feel like to have him, and not her husband, slamming into her long after she came, and then filling her with his hot seed.

Michael groaned and clutched her hips to him when he came.

They panted for a while on the couch, Raine's pussy still throbbing around his cock.

He reached down and pulled on her shoulder, bringing her up to his chest. His skin was hot and sweaty against her back. His fingers played with her breasts, stroked her rib cage, closed momentarily around her neck. His breath was hot against her ear. She felt incredible: worn out, dizzy, sexually *satisfied*.

He was still inside of her. "That was *hot*," he said.

His cock pulsed inside her body, as though to prove it.

"You're not mad?" she asked, a little perplexed.

She turned around, his cock flopping out of her. It was still almost completely hard, she noticed. She reclined on the throw pillows and pushed her hair from her face.

"Mad?" he said. "I pretty much pushed you into doing it."

Raine brought her thumb to her teeth and bit gently into her nail.

"You don't feel bad about it, do you?" Michael asked, sitting down on the couch next to her.

She rubbed her face. "I don't know. I can't... I just... yeah I guess I feel a little bad," she sighed. "I just mean... what are we *doing*?"

Michael pushed her hair out of her face. "I don't know," he said. "Living out a fantasy, I guess."

Raine returned to biting her thumbnail.

"But *why* is it a fantasy?" she asked.

Michael sighed. "Did you have a good time? With him?"

Raine waited. She wasn't sure how to answer the question. What did he want to hear?

"I don't know what to say to that," she said plainly. "I don't... I just can't believe that it doesn't bother you, or make you jealous."

Michael settled on the couch and caressed her leg, pulling her foot onto his lap and starting to massage it gently. "It does. That's what I'm

trying to explain to you. It's kind of the appeal."

She said nothing.

"Does it bother *you* that I like that?"

She thought about it. Did it bother her?

She knew it *should*. Everything she thought she had ever believed about relationships said this was all wrong.

"This just doesn't seem like a good idea," she said. "I feel like... I don't know. Like something is going to go really, really wrong."

But as soon as she said this, she realized what the appeal of it all was. Precisely that: the feeling that it all might go wrong.

Michael leaned his head back on the couch. "Raine," he said. "I don't want you doing anything you don't want to do. But..." he slid his hand down her still-sticky inner thigh, "it seems like there's *something* appealing about it to you."

Raine rubbed her face.

"What's the problem?" Michael said. "If we're all having a good time? Don't you feel like our sex life has been better? I do."

Raine felt his cock throb against her ankle. There was no denying what he was saying: they had been growing distant and distracted for many years now, and that wasn't how things felt now. It was strange that something that should have been tearing them apart was actually bringing them together. But something still nagged at her.

"It just doesn't feel... right," she said.

Michael paused, running his hand along her leg. "Why not?"

"I don't know. I guess I just... I don't really know. I don't want you to think of me differently."

"Like what?" he asked.

"Like, I don't know. Like I'm a slut, or something."

There was a long pause.

"I don't think that," he said quietly.

Raine didn't say anything.

"Okay, listen," he said, pulling her close to him. "That was incredibly hot. I promise, I liked it. But I don't want you to do anything you don't want to do. Okay? So... I don't know. If you want to go further, I think I'm okay with it."

“This is what I don’t get,” Raine said. “Why are you okay with me sleeping with another man?”

Michael appeared to search his mind for a good answer. It was clear he didn’t really have one. He started to shrug his shoulders, when Raine interjected, unable to stop herself:

“Because I’m *not* okay with you sleeping with another woman. Just so you know. In fact, that’s what -”

She cut herself off.

“That’s what, what?” Michael asked.

Raine rubbed her forehead. “That’s what I thought you were doing in Columbus. It’s why... I was so excited to come down there.”

There was a long silence.

A huge weight lifted itself from Raine's chest. She actually felt it, like it was easier to breathe having finally confronted this fear about Michael, however absurdly the topic had come about.

Michael laughed abruptly, and her face got hot with anger.

His expression changed as he recognized that she was angered. He reached for her hands, which she was about to flail around in fury.

“Raine,” he said.

“Don’t laugh at me, it’s not funny!”

“Hey. It’s only funny because... that’s like, the last thing I would ever do. That’s all.”

She colored with deeper anger, welling up from somewhere inexplicable inside of her. “I hardly see how you expect me to believe that, when you’re telling me it’s okay to have an affair with -”

“Hey, whoa. I did *not* say it’s okay to have an *affair* with anyone.”

“Well, have sex with him. That’s what *I* mean by affair.”

He squeezed her hand. “Let’s... walk this back for a second, okay? And you, listen to what I’m saying, because I’m being serious now. One, I’m not having an affair or sex with another woman and two, I don’t want to.” He sighed. “I want to have sex with *you*. And I want you to be excited about it again. That’s all. And so this...” he waved his hand in the direction of the neighbor’s house, “This changed everything between *us*. Right? So that’s what the appeal is, okay?”

Raine's anger crushed inside of her, and it felt as if a bubble had burst, flooding her with relief and sadness. A tear welled up in her right eye,

which always started to pour before her left eye did. Michael wiped the tear away with his finger as soon as it spilled over. “Hey. It’s been a good thing. But if that’s enough, too far, whatever, then okay. Let’s end it here. Okay?”

Raine nodded, though she wasn't sure what she was agreeing to, exactly.

Michael pulled her to him, and kissed the top of her head.

The outcome of the conversation was dissatisfying, but she supposed it would have to suffice for now. She had more to say, but she was conflicted inside, wanting to stop all of this, whatever it was.

And not wanting to stop it at all. Wanting to see where it took them, liking the danger of it so close to her.

But it was madness to actually *go through* with something like that.

It was all just fantasy, and that's what it would be forever.

Wasn't it?

CHAPTER 11

“Oh fucking hell,” Michael said under his breath.

A black man had just entered the corner liquor store, and though he only saw him from the back, he was pretty sure it was his neighbor Gabe. Unless there were hordes of other tall, muscled black guys living around here, which wasn't likely.

He frowned as he looked around the parking lot: there was the silver Beemer. It had to be Gabe, sure enough.

The air was still on, the car still running. He could just back out and come back later. No problem.

But that made him feel like an ass. A pussy. A cuck.

After all, the guy was just a neighbor. He *wanted* him to fuck his wife, after all. Shouldn't he be able to look the guy in the eye?

Maybe not today. Michael thought quickly, and after scanning the parking lot again for a way out of running into Gabe at the liquor store, he found his escape: the Mexican food restaurant that did take-out. He'd go in there, order the food, wait for it, and pass by the liquor store afterward. Raine would like the surprise, and he could put off the inevitable conversation with the man who had fingered his wife for another day.

He saw Gabe everywhere now. He was at the supermarket, the gas station. There were neighbors he didn't see more than once a year, and then there was Gabe. Why was it that he hadn't disappeared into the anonymity of the suburbs? It seemed like he saw him more since the events at his party, too.

Michael stepped out of the car and moved as efficiently as he could toward the Mexican place at the end of the covered walkway. He had considered re-parking the car, but that was a little too cowardly even for him. Plus what if Gabe came out and saw him?

His reluctance to talk to Gabe made him realize that he maybe wasn't the swinger he thought he was. After all, if he really was okay with all of this, wouldn't he be able to look the guy in the eye, shake his hand, and be cool with it?

The menu swarmed in front of his face. The inside of the Mexican place was so cold it ruined his appetite, and the change of temperature made him nauseous. He scanned the menu, went with the classics, and stood by a newspaper stand to wait, with a copy of the Rocky Gazette, a neighborhood paper, in his fingers.

The door opened and closed, and Michael would later swear he had some sense of what was about to happen, but he didn't look up.

He heard Gabe's voice, ordering six tacos a la gringa, guacamole and chips. His blood ran cold.

"Oh. Hey, man."

Gabe was in front of him, a dark figure, enormous, sort of blocking out the sun. Michael looked up at him, and folded the paper quickly just in case his hand started shaking.

The thing is, it didn't. In fact, standing there, face to face with Gabe, he didn't feel at all like what he had been fearing.

"Gabe," he said. "Hey."

They shook hands – the same forceful grip from Gabe, and Michael returned it. He regretted ordering the carnitas now, because they had to cook more of them, which sadly was the fate of the meat for Gabe's meal as well.

"Gonna be a while," the waitress said, and Michael was just about to cancel his order and get out of there, when she offered them Coronas on the house while they waited.

"Can't turn that down," Gabe said. "You in a hurry, man?"

Michael took the already-opened Corona from across the counter and shrugged. There wasn't much to be done if he didn't want to look like an ass.

They sat down in one of the booths, where few people ate. The restaurant, which had been taken over from a Chinese place, without doing much about the décor, had an odd and unpleasant vibe about it. Black mirrored walls were struck through with gold marbling, the booths were an odious yellow plastic, and sombreros that looked as if they had actually been worn in a field hung where the three-paneled Chinese paintings had once been. But, like the Chinese restaurant before it (which probably closed down because of tax evasion), the food was delicious, so the take-out business was good and the dine-in business was nonexistent.

Michael slid into the booth and Gabe tipped his Corona bottle at him. The glass bottles clinked and they each took a sip.

“Anybody ever eat in here?” Gabe said, scowling at the décor.

“Doubt it,” Michael said. “It’s pretty grim.”

Gabe took another sip of his beer.

There was an awkward pause, which Michael felt compelled to fill. “So what brings you to Rocky River?” he asked.

Gabe raised his eyebrow, and for a second Michael was sure he had stepped in it.

“I just mean because... I don’t know, you have a Beemer, no kids. Sort of seems like a weird choice of neighborhood. For a guy like you.”

He was only making it worse.

Gabe’s face was cold and expressionless for a moment, and then he broke out into a smile. “You aren’t gonna bust my chops about taxes are you?”

Michael was taken aback. “I...what? No. Taxes? That’s... yeah, no, that’s none of my business.”

Something he really disliked about himself was how flustered he got around this guy.

“It’s a write-off,” Gabe said, and then took such a long time drinking his beer Michael was sure that was the end of his thoughts on the matter. He racked his brains for something to say. Gabe set his beer down. “I have a house in University Circle.”

Michael raised his eyebrows. “That’s... a nice neighborhood...”

“You know, I just needed the write-off.”

“It’s a long way from University Circle, though.”

Gabe looked at him. “I have some relatives I gotta check on nearby,” he said.

Michael had no idea if this was a lie or the truth, but he also decided he didn’t want to pry.

“Look, you’re my landlord so I probably shouldn’t say this, but I had plans to Air Bnb the place half the time.”

Michael laughed. It was a fairly obvious fake laugh, because he actually had no idea how he felt about that, or if he should care. “What happened?”

Gabe shrugged. "It's probably just not worth it. I don't like a lot of hassle."

This effectively killed the conversation, and left Michael with the feeling he'd had some of his questions about their strange neighbor answered, and a lot of new ones develop.

Michael felt an opening. He wasn't sure what it was about the conversation that made him feel that way, all he knew was he did.

"So listen, man," he said. He looked sideways, and was relieved to see that the staff were tucked away in the kitchen. "I uh, gotta set the record straight on something."

Gabe looked interested. He took up his beer again. "Oh yeah?"

Michael looked at the table, where some salt had been spilled, and he pushed it into a little pile as he spoke. "I, uh... I was in Columbus about three weeks ago. And, uh... I saw you there."

The features on Gabe's face, to his surprise, looked truly surprised for a moment. Michael held his hands up quickly, to indicate that he wasn't bothered by what he had seen. "Hey man, I'm cool with it," he started to say.

At the same time he was talking, Gabe smile wryly. "Oh you did, did you?"

It was because he was talking that Michael didn't know if he heard Gabe's question correctly. It also sounded like he put the emphasis on "you." Oh *you* did, did you?

Gabe spoke next. "You were at the Hyatt?"

Michael nodded and gave a careless shrug. No big deal to him.

Gabe took a sip of his beer. "So, those are some... acquaintances. I'm sure you can see we have an arrangement."

Michael nodded. "Look, man, I'm not trying to get in your business, I just... wanted you to know I saw you, is all."

"Mmm," Gabe said noncommittally. "And what'd you think?"

Michael looked at him, stomach twisting. After all, this was the guy who had fingered his wife, right at the breakfast bar, in front of a whole party of people. Did he know that Michael knew about that?

More importantly, did he care?

"I.. uh... you know. It's your business. I uh, I only told you because I didn't want it coming up later or something." Michael said.

“Hmm,” Gabe said, eyeing him as he lifted the last of his Corona to his lips. “You’re not interested in it *at all*?”

Michael felt like his entire abdomen was falling through the floor.

“Listen man, I told you. I don’t like a lot of hassle. But I can see a guy who’s interested in something when I see him. You look like that kind of guy to me.”

Michael leaned back in the booth. “How’s something like that work?” he asked. “I mean, how do you even find, you know...”

Gabe chuckled. He turned abruptly to the woman behind the counter. “Hey, can we get two more Coronas?”

“Your food is ready,” she said.

“Bring it out here, we’ll eat it here.”

Michael started to object, but his curiosity got the best of him.

Gabe turned toward him, elbows on the table, fist balled inside the opposite hand. He looked even more foreboding with his muscles flexed like that. “A couple like that,” he said, “I find on the internet.”

“You’re kidding me.”

Gabe cocked his head. “Oh come on, man. You’ve never been on the internet before? There’s all kinds of shit out there.”

Michael took his last swig of beer. “So these are like, married couples.... Who.....”

Gabe smiled. The waitress came along with the beers and opened them at the table. Gabe kept smiling, thanked her, and kept his eyes fixed on Michael.

“Who like to have a black man fuck the wife,” Gabe said, and the comment seemed to come out of nowhere because of the interruption.

Just like that. Plain as day.

Michael could feel his jaw slacken, so he made a conscious effort to pull his mouth closed. His heart was racing.

“It’s not an uncommon thing,” Gabe said, as though trying to make him feel better.

Michael took a long drink to steady himself. He reminded himself that Gabe quite possibly didn’t know that Raine had told him about the night of the party. He might think he was baiting him, and he might not.

Either way, he needed to say something, and he decided to just go with his honest curiosity. “So you just, meet up with these people and

then...”

“Screw their wives?” Gabe smiled. “Exactly.”

“Whoa.”

Another awkward silence.

“Does that ever get complicated?” Michael asked.

Gabe popped open his box of tacos, which the waitress had somehow brought to the table without Michael noticing. He stabbed at some lettuce with a plastic fork and shoved it in his mouth. “Man, I told you. I don’t like any hassle. I like married women, they don’t want to tie the knot. But I don’t like angry husbands. I also like white women. Nice, pretty little blondes... or brunettes... with creamy white skin and tiny little... mouths.”

Michael could not help his growing erection. He was sure he knew what Gabe wanted in a tiny little... mouth.

“Some guys like to watch a black guy fuck their wife. Works out for everyone.” Gabe took a bite of his taco, which took down almost the entire thing. He chewed and swallowed it in a second, then popped the final piece into his great, gnashing mouth.

He picked up another one, and shook some of the loose cheese and sauce out of it. “Now. I don’t usually shit where I eat,” he said. “But I figure, I’ll be out of this place in a few months anyway” He looked up at Michael sternly. “That’s not official notice,” he cracked.

Michael was too stunned to speak.

“Man, don’t act like you aren’t into it. And that wife of yours is *definitely* game. And *I* am definitely game for that tight little pussy -”

“That’s my wife!” Michael said. Only because he felt he should.

Gabe grinned with one corner of his mouth and stuffed the entire taco in. He ate it with only about three grinding chews, and then he wiped his mouth with the back of his hand. “And you’re gonna tell me you wouldn’t like it just fine if I had her sitting on my lap with her nice little tits bouncing and her pussy all full of my big, black nigger cock?”

Michael’s mouth fell open.

“I’ve heard worse man, it don’t even make me blink.”

He folded the tacos closed and dumped the Corona down his throat. Then he set a \$100 bill on the table. He wiped his hands and set the napkin down, and then he punched his fists together. “Look. All I’m saying is: if you’re game then you’re game, and I’m game, so if y’all want to, we can

work something out. Not something I'd usually do, but your wife is..." He made a sucking sound through his teeth, and grinned.

When Michael said nothing, he shrugged and made a gesture at the bill on the table. "It's on me, man," he said, looking at the bill on the table.

Michael watched as he stood up.

"Raine feels too guilty about it," he blurted. "Otherwise... you know."

Gabe looked down at him. "Oh, I see."

He decided he had something on his face, and picked up a napkin to wipe his big mouth again.

"You can leave that to me," he said, rubbing his hands together. "Anyway, sometimes it's fun when they feel guilty. For you."

He nodded at Michael, as though he knew exactly what he meant by that, and Michael's neck burned. The audacity!

But at the same time, his cock was hard as a rock, and his balls were pulsing almost painfully.

And before Michael could be sure that's what he wanted to do, or say something in reply – anything! - Gabe had picked up his tacos, waved at the waitress, and was stepping out the door. Cool as a cucumber, as if he hadn't just talked to someone about how he was going to fuck his wife. In her nice, tight mouth.

CHAPTER 12

Raine squinted at her phone. The sun was bouncing up and down the screen in time with her jogging, so she slowed, in the hopes she would get a better idea of where she and Brenna had gotten lost in the system of parks and pathways that cut through neighborhoods and industrial parks and fields, all the way downtown.

“...so I said, okay cowboy, let’s do it, and I turned around and walked out of the club, you know, thinking he was following me, and you would not believe what – hey, Raine, whoa!”

Raine looked up from the map just in time to swerve out of the way of an enormous tree root that had upended the sidewalk, but because she saw it so late, she went into the tree and stumbled and fell onto the grass.

Her phone went flying out of her hand, and Brenna, not one to be good in any situation resembling an emergency, covered her face and said, “Shit!”

Raine had gone through a very clumsy stage in her adolescent years, because her legs were long and gangly and she had the coordination of a newborn colt for about a year. So she was familiar with the cycle of a fall like this: first swirling, then the *idea* of pain as a knee, or an elbow, or a head, contacted something.

The actual pain would come seconds later, when the brain caught up with what was happening.

As she went down, she could feel that her hip, her knee, her stomach, and her chin were all going to feel pain. It was a bad one.

She lay on the grass and rolled into a fetal position, and that’s when her body parts started reporting back to her.

It wasn’t too bad. A bruise maybe. A scrape on her knee definitely.

“She tripped on that tree branch,” she heard Brenna saying.

Raine opened her eyes. Was she going crazy or had she heard a deep baritone voice say: “What happened?”

The sun was in her eyes. And then it was blocked out.

“Raine? You okay?”

She felt a hand on her arm, pulling her up as she tried to push herself up. She rested her arms on her knees.

Because of her gangly years, she had learned to play off clumsiness as a cute feature of her personality, and not show her embarrassment about it.

“Oh, wow,” she said. “That was a good one.”

“You okay?” It was definitely him.

Gabe.

He crouched in front of her, his ropes of leg muscle straining against his skin. Raine averted her eyes from the center of his legs, but a wild wave of heat traveled through her body.

“I fall all the time,” she said. His hand was on her forearm and it was burning through her skin. She had goosebumps forming on her shoulder blades.

“She does,” Brenna said. Raine could see her take a step closer to the neighbor, and start to twist her hips a little. Brenna was single, horny, and liked black guys, if you believed what she said. She noticed that Brenna angled her thigh outward, in a very transparent attempt to get Gabe to admire the length of her tanned leg.

“Lemme help you up,” Gabe said, without looking at Brenna, who was shamelessly twisting her body now like a photo shoot for the new cover of *Lolita*. “If you’re okay.”

She nodded. He took both of her forearms in his hands and from a crouch, stood up. She felt herself levitating as though she weighed no more than a piece of paper.

Which made her think of all kinds of very, very dirty things.

Her abdomen churned wildly. She looked up at Gabe. “What are you doing here?” she asked.

He smiled, looking down at her running garb. He was likewise outfitted, though his shirt – a tank top – barely covered his muscled shoulders, the guns of his arms, or the layers of muscles along his ribs and what appeared to be a clearly defined six-pack. “Same as you,” he said.

At that exact moment, though, Brenna said: “Hi, I’m Brenna,” cheerfully, putting her hand out for him to shake.

Gabe gave her a polite handshake, and a smile, and then turned back to Raine. He put his fingers gently under her chin, and lifted it to look at the

small scrape she could now feel burning on her skin. “That’s gonna sting,” he said. “You better go clean it out. I can go get the car if you want.”

Raine was suddenly embarrassed. “Actually if you could just -”

But Brenna was talking over her. “That’s a great idea. She really took a header.”

“I’m fine,” Raine snapped to Brenna. “We’re...I’m fine. I just, we actually got lost, which is why...”

She was about to say, “I was looking for my phone,” but she left the sentence unfinished as she looked around for it. She saw it on the sidewalk and took a step to pick it up.

An excruciating pain traveled through her ankle. “Ow!” she couldn’t help exclaiming.

Gabe was right there to support her. He swung her arm up over his shoulder, and all of his tense muscles were against her skin, the underside of her arm, and her body was reacting in... well, the wrong way. For a married woman.

“Girl, you have to take it easy, I think you sprained your ankle.” He looked around. “Here. There’s a bench over there.”

He walked her to it and helped her sit down, while starry-eyed Brenna made a face at her and fanned herself behind his back. Raine glared at her. She wasn’t helping matters at all.

“This really isn’t...I just need a rest.”

“Nonsense,” Gabe said. “I’ll pop over and get the car.”

“I’ll be fine, really,” Raine said. She actually *did* want him to get the car, and she wouldn’t mind him picking her up and putting her in it, and then taking her back home... but she was feeling way too many inappropriate emotions for that.

“I don’t wanna carry you all the way home,” Gabe said. “You’re like a lead weight.”

This was obviously a joke, so he didn’t bother smiling much about it.

“So you just sit tight with uh...”

“Brenna.”

“Brenna here, and I’ll be back in about ten.”

Brenna had moved to the bench, and she put her hand on Raine’s shoulder and squeezed almost painfully. “That is just what we’ll do,” she

said. “Won’t we? And thank you so much. Really. It’s so lucky you came by.”

Gabe smiled for her, and turned to run back in the direction he had come from as the two ladies watched him go.

“Oh. My. God,” Brenna said. “Oh, my fucking God. Who *is* this guy?”

Raine rubbed her face. “Oh, God. It’s my neighbor,” she said.

“Oh, God, it’s my neighbor?” What is *your problem*? Why doesn’t my neighbor look like that? Did you *see* how big his cock is?”

“Brenna!” Raine hissed.

As soon as she did, she realized her mistake: Brenna always talked like that, and Raine always ignored her. By reacting to what she said, she’d keyed Brenna in on something.

“Oh my God!” she yelled, squeezing her fists together and plopping onto the bench. “Oh my God! You have a *thing* for him, don’t you?! Oh my God. Don’t tell me, you’ve already done it with him. You have. I can tell. Your face is turning so red.” She leaned back on the bench. “Not that I blame -”

“Brenna, shut up. Nothing happened.”

Brenna looked at her. “Well, that’s not true. I can tell because you’re... yeah, no, now that I think about it, the way he was touching you...” She made a noise. “*Man*.”

Brenna put her face in her hands.

“Oh *God*, Raine, I’m not going to *say* anything to anyone, I just... I mean, is this an ongoing thing, or like, is it over? And if it’s *over*...”

Brenna drifted off. “Oh. This is serious. Okay... look, I was joking, okay?” She put her hand on her back. “You didn’t actually...?”

Raine shook her head.

“But you want to...?” Brenna said.

Raine sat up and sighed. She didn’t like talking about herself, or her personal feelings, or her marriage, especially not with Brenna. But the whole situation had been eating away at her for the past three weeks, since she had decided that she had better just stay away from her neighbor Gabe.

Staying away from him was easy, but keeping her mind off of him was not. In fact, she had started to think about him almost obsessively.

And now she felt like she needed to talk. She looked at her hands. "So, uh... there's, I can't say how this happened, but, um... so... ugh. I don't know how to say this. So... Michael is sort of, like..."

"Into it?"

Brenna was not fussed. Or surprised.

And now Raine was.

Brenna was nodding. She fished her water bottle out of her side pack and took a sip, then offered some to Raine, who shook her head. "You would be *amazed* how many guys are into that. You mean you having sex with him, right?"

Raine's mouth was open. She knew that Brenna was a sexual libertine and everything, but she hadn't quite expected this level of... blasé disclosure about something that Raine herself felt was pretty "out there."

Brenna looked at her. "Oh, don't look at me like that." She leaned back on the bench and spread her arms over the back of it. "I say, take advantage of it."

Raine leaned back as well. "What?"

Brenna shrugged. "Take advantage of it. If Michael's into it, I mean... *look* at the fucking guy. I bet his cock is like, twelve inches long and this thick."

She made an obscenely large circle with her fingers.

Raine snorted. "That's not everything, you know."

Brenna wiped her nose. "Sure it's not. But I will tell you something. I have yet to be disappointed by a black guy. So maybe a big cock isn't everything, but maybe if you have a big cock it gives you insight into what is, because seriously..."

Raine shook her head.

"I'm married," she said desperately.

"And your husband wants you to go get a piece of that gorgeous black man. What is your *problem*?"

Raine clammed up. Brenna wasn't married, and she probably never would be. It was hard to imagine it. And if she did ever get married, Raine would have been the first to put money on it lasting less than a year.

So she was the *last* person Raine was going to take marriage advice from.

"Just be careful," Brenna said.

The Beemer turned the corner and she stopped talking as it slowed and approached the curb. “Oh Jesus fuck, is this his car?”

Raine said nothing.

“I was gonna say, be careful, cuz once you go black...”

And then she stopped talking, and turned on her most radiant smile for Gabe, who was stepping out of the car.

“Nice wheels,” she said, putting a hand on her hip suggestively.

Gabe handed her the keys. “Wanna drive us home?”

Brenna was standing with the keys in her hand, making a face that looked a lot like a stunned fish, as Gabe helped Raine up. “I’ll get you in the back, so you can stretch your foot out.”

“Oh no, not on your seats,” she said, as she saw the tan leather interior.

Gabe’s hand traveled down her spine, over the center of her running shorts. A tickle traveled through her, and she felt a roll of sweat fatten and drip down her back. His breath was on her neck when he said: “I’ll make an exception for you, darlin.”

Raine’s whole body was set on fire. She felt like jell-o as he helped her into the back of the car. She didn’t have enough energy to resist the way he settled her in, with her feet up, because it was actually very unnecessary. He drew his hand along her calves as he backed out of the rear seat.

“Okay, Brenna,” he said. “Take us home.”

When they reached Raine’s house, which Gabe directed her to with ease, he came around to the driver’s-side door and pulled her gently by her ankles toward the opening. His hands moved up her calves, behind her knee, where they lingered, making a slow and delicate circle on the back of it. Gabe pursed his lips and said in a low growl: “I see you like that.” Then, changing the subject, he scooped his arm under her leg and said, “Grab my shoulders.”

And then he carried her into the house.

It was totally, outrageously inappropriate. She could walk, after all. She didn’t need to have the dampness of his sweat against her cheek, or her own legs getting sticky as the feel of his rock-hard muscle everywhere it touched her made her wet.

Brenna was making goo-goo eyes at her as Gabe carried her in and set her down on the couch in the living room. Raine racked her brain for a way to do the right thing (and get him to leave) without actually closing any doors on the possibilities she had with Gabe. The result was utter confusion in her mind, so she said nothing while Gabe said, “Y’all got an ice pack or something?” and walked into her kitchen without waiting for a response.

“Oh. My. God.” Brenna mouthed at Raine. “I’ll help you!” she sang, practically skipping into the kitchen.

They returned a moment later with a bag of ice wrapped in a towel.

“You know, Gabe,” Raine said, finding her voice. “I’m... I think I’m good now, I, really, I don’t want to put you out any more than I already have. Thanks so much for the ride.”

Gabe gave her a look, just seconds longer than it needed to be, but for those few seconds, his gaze burned a hole right through her.

“Okay, I guess you’ll be okay. You put some weight on it, right? It’s not broken?”

“It’s good,” she said. “I’ll just rest it and see what happens.”

Gabe smiled. “Uh, okay then. Just shoot me a call if you need anything.”

Raine started to frown, not sure if she had his number or not.

“I got it,” Brenna said, and while Raine wondered how that had happened, she didn’t really want to know.

Gabe left. Brenna was arranging the towel and ice pack around Raine’s foot, which Raine was pretty sure actually felt okay now. Brenna waited until about five seconds after the door clicked to turn around and look out the window.

“Are you fucking *kidding me*?” she said.

“Brenna,” Raine started.

“He is so fucking into you. Where does he live? Mmm. I do *not* see any men like that in my neighborhood.”

“Brenna, seriously...”

Brenna shook her head. “You gonna do him, or what?”

Raine looked at her, dumbfounded. “Brenna!”

“Just askin.’ For a friend.” She stuck out her tongue. “I know, I know, you’re married. Blah blah. But dude, an opportunity like that comes once in

a lifetime.” She pushed her hair back with two hands. “Phew. I am *hot* just watching you two lovebirds.”

Raine fell silent.

Brenna nudged her playfully with her knee. “Soooo hot, when he picked you up and carried you in.”

Raine said nothing.

“Oh. My. God,” Brenna said. “Ohmygod. You already *did him*, you huge fucking slut. Tell me all about it. He has a twelve-inch cock, right? I’m always -”

“I didn’t do that,” Raine said quietly.

Brenna sat down next to her. “Well, you did *something*.”

Raine still said nothing.

Brenna put her hand on her arm. “Okay, okay, I’m sorry. But listen, how bad was it? It’s not cheating if you didn’t, you know...”

Raine closed her eyes and leaned her head back. “That’s just it... it’s not cheating...” she moaned.

Brenna squinted at her until she opened her eyes. “Huh?”

Raine moved her head from side to side. Brenna was definitely not the queen of discretion, so she didn’t think it was all that safe to divulge *anything* to her. She needed to talk to someone about it, though, and if anyone was going to be liberal enough to understand it, it would be Brenna.

She rubbed her eyes with the pads of her fingers anyway. “You have to promise me you’re not going to say anything,” she said.

Brenna shrugged. “I can try.”

Raine opened her eyes and gave her a look. Brenna shrugged again. “You know me,” she said. “It just.. depends on what it is.”

“Brenna...”

“Okay okay okay fine,” she said, and then mimed zipping her lips shut.

Raine sighed. “So, uh... Michael is like, kind of, I don’t know... like he says, and I don’t know if I believe it, but he says that he’s uh... I can’t believe I’m saying this -”

“I can’t believe it’s taking you so looooong to say it,” Brenna groaned. “What is it? He’s into it? He wants to watch? What?”

Raine was shocked, so her mouth fell open and she stared at her friend. “How... how’d...”

Brenna rolled her eyes. “Oh, my God, what do you live in the fifties or something? I’ve had like three boyfriends who were into this same thing, wanting me to have sex with another guy, and two of them were like, unapologetically, all, do a black guy.”

Raine was still in shock so she continued staring for a moment. Finally, she found her voice. “So what’d you do?”

Brenna snorted. “What do you think I did?” She leaned forward to touch Raine on the arm. “Look, if you are getting a free pass to fuck *that* guy, and you aren’t using it, you are fucking crazy. Crazy. I mean, *look at him.*”

Raine chewed on her lips and shook her head. “But... how did it work out, you know? Like, did they sit there and watch you? And then what happened?”

Brenna smiled. “That’s actually the best part. Think about it. He’s sitting there watching you. Plus, you’re married, right? It’s like, some guys, they want you to do all this really filthy stuff but they can’t do it to you themselves. At least this is what my last boyfriend said. So if you do it with some other guy they can, like, get off on it.”

Raine was making a displeased face. “Like, what kinds of things?”

Brenna looked at her. “What do you mean, what kinds of things? Stuff you wouldn’t do with him. Is your sex life at *all* interesting? It can’t be. You guys are like, too busy respecting each other and all that shit. But you can do *anything* with this guy.”

Brenna was grinning. Raine felt herself getting turned on, sort of against her own will. She looked down to avoid blushing in front of her friend.

“Oh, Jesus,” Brenna said. “Don’t you ever just want to act like a slut? Stick your finger in your own ass and get spanked by a big, delicious black guy, and feel what it’s like to have a huge cock up your ass?”

“Brenna! God! No!”

Brenna was nodding. “You do. That’s *exactly* what you want to do. You just don’t want to do it with Michael because, let’s face it, he’s just too nice and it would be, like, I dunno, sort of boring. But if you fuck this guy, he’s going to throw you around and like, really *fuck* you. So if Michael is okay with it, then why not?”

Raine had no idea what to say. She waved at her friend. “Let’s change the subject,” she said, to which Brenna agreed by picking up a magazine and rolling her eyes.

But Raine didn’t stop thinking about it. In fact, the more she thought about it – even in Brenna’s extremely crude and vulgar terminology – the more enticing the idea became to her.

Still she wouldn’t *do* it.

This kind of thing never turned out the way people wanted. It would all end in tears, she just knew it.

Knowing it didn’t stop Brenna’s voice from playing on a loop in her head, along with some explicit imagery: *Stick your finger in your own ass and get spanked by a big, delicious black guy and feel what it’s like to have a huge cock up your ass.*

These were all things she wanted to do, in the back of her mind, it was true.

But she couldn’t do them with Michael, that was also true.

But could she do them with the neighbor?

CHAPTER 13

“.... and then luckily, uh, we ran into Gabe... our neighbor.... And he, uh, gave me a quick ride home.”

Raine was pointing in the direction of Gabe’s house, looking down at the food she was stirring around on her plate. As though he didn’t know who Gabe was, as though he would just forget.

“Gabe, huh?” he said suggestively.

The conversation with Gabe at the restaurant still lingered in his mind. Constantly, day and night. Gabe talking about his wife’s tight little mouth, Gabe feeding his cock into that mouth, Raine gasping in pleasure as he slipped between her wet thighs...

Leave that to me.

Raine was flustered again. She tucked a strand of her hair behind her ear and shrugged. “It was a really lucky thing,” she said. “He was out... jogging too, I guess.”

I bet, Michael thought, and for a moment he was tempted to tell Raine about his conversation at the restaurant.

But an even deeper desire within him subsumed the compulsion to share with her: it was the compulsion to watch his wife get seduced by Gabe. A seduction he was hoping was unsuccessful as much as he was hoping it was successful.

“That’s lucky,” he said, trying to sound neutral, and not like a man who had essentially agreed to let another man seduce his wife. “You okay now?”

Raine nodded, scooping her food up and turning her fork upside down to dump it back out again. “It really wasn’t that big of a deal. I feel kind of silly about it, actually.”

He couldn’t tell how Raine really felt. She didn’t seem especially flustered by the experience. Had anything more happened between the two of them while she was “jogging?” And if it had, would she tell him? And how would he find out?

“I’m glad you’re okay,” Michael said.

He had an erection, thinking about Gabe “helping” his wife out. He took a few bites of food.

If Gabe wanted him to “leave it to him,” then that’s what he would do.

“Uh, so listen,” Michael said. He had been planning, before this conversation about Raine’s injury, to tell her how he had two consecutive business-packed days in Columbus. He would have to stay overnight, and he’d been intending to suggest that she come with him, stay in that same hotel, and hopefully they would have their memories jogged by the place and have a wild night.

As soon as he started to suggest the idea, though, he thought better of it.

“So... listen,” he repeated, and Raine looked at him quizzically, her fork in midair.

He scrambled for something to say, his plan taking shape in his mind as he spoke. “I have to go to Columbus on Thursday, and it’s a really packed couple of days. Meetings. All day long, into the evening. I have to stay overnight. I, um... I’m thinking, my schedule is so packed... originally I was going to say that you should come, but I think, well, given the circumstances... you should just stay here.”

His eyes, involuntarily, wandered to the window to look out through the glass at the sloped hill leading down to Gabe’s house.

Raine kept her eyes on his, but discreetly did not react to where he had looked. He wondered if she would read “under the circumstances” to mean “Gabe,” as he pretty much meant when he said it. Or if he were just imagining his wife’s attraction to Gabe, her willingness to break the bonds of their marriage and explore, and her secrecy.

She picked up a glass of water. “Well... I mean, if you have something until late, and something in the morning, I guess we couldn’t have much fun.”

Her tone was suggestive. At least he thought so. And she was agreeing rather quickly to being left behind, almost as though he had handed her an opportunity and she was now taking it.

Did it all mean what he thought it meant?

He felt, suddenly, like taking it all back. His implicit “agreement” with Gabe, his suggestion that Raine stay here. But the whole scheme was

set in motion, gathering momentum, and he felt powerless to stop it.

He shook his head slowly in response to her statement. "It won't be very fun *there*. I just.. uh, are you... okay to stay here yourself?"

"Of course."

Her answer was so immediate, so out of character, that Michael was stunned.

His stomach twisted into a tight knot and his cock stiffened.

She eased a napkin out from under the fork. He wondered what she was thinking, what she was plotting. Had Gabe already worked his magic on her?

He thought about asking her outright, right there at the table. After all, they'd pretty much talked about it. She'd gone as far as to let Gabe finger her at the party. What was one step further, in the big picture?

If she'd made up her mind to do it, he wanted her to talk about it. That was half the fun.

But it was equally exciting to think that Raine was going to do something all on her own, without telling him, without asking for permission first. Would that be cheating on him, if he had already tried to get her to do it and basically given his permission to her?

He didn't know.

And he also didn't know why he found it so titillating, but he did. His cock was pulsing to life under the table. Throbbing with a desire, however perverted, to have his wife sneak around on him, fucking Gabe.

Maybe she wouldn't. And maybe that was what he wanted, deep down inside.

Maybe she would. And that idea excited him, even if he knew it shouldn't.

He looked over at his wife: her petite frame, her alabaster skin, the flawless curve of her doll-like mouth. Why did he want to see her thoroughly defiled by their neighbor?

He was tied in knots again.

It was his call, he knew: if he said to her right then: "Please don't get up to anything with Gabe, I retract any implicit permission I have given you," he knew that she could be trusted.

All he had to do was say something. Say something to her now.

All she had to do was double-check.

The clock ticked away in the silence.

“Oh!” Raine exclaimed, jumping up from her seat. “I almost forgot. Brenna brought me this really good wine to thank me for the help on that project we did with the... doesn’t matter. Anyway, you want some? It’s some super-fancy stuff she got from her job.”

She was already getting it, already moving on, already talking about wine.

He looked at the bottle as she held it in one hand and slid a drawer open with the other, looking for the bottle opener.

“You know what?” he said. His chest felt tight as he spoke. “Let’s not waste that on an evening like tonight.”

She turned around to face him. The air was electric between them.

“Save it for a special occasion,” he added.

She closed the drawer by pushing against it with her bottom, and shrugged.

“Maybe you can give it to Gabe,” he suggested.

There was a delicious pause while she looked at him, and the tension simmered for a moment.

“For helping you out today,” he finished.

Raine lifted a hand to her face, and pushed her hair back. He was certain he saw her tremble a little. She set the wine on the counter, and trailed her fingers down the bottle. He was not sure if the gesture was intended or some subconscious sensuality that came with the thought of Gabe, but it instantly planted images in his mind of her white fingers on his dark cock.

“Good idea,” she said quietly.

CHAPTER 14

She wasn't sure if she had intended to do it all along. She certainly put on a good show for herself, of deliberating about it, acting like it was a good idea, then changing her mind, then resolving to watch TV all night and drink the wine herself.

But she had a sneaking suspicion she had actually been resolved to do it all along, ever since the universe had sent her a sign of sorts, when Michael had not wanted to drink the wine – wine that she hadn't gotten from Brenna at all, but bought herself, as a thank-you for Gabe.

And then, she was pretty certain, he had basically suggested that she do exactly what she was doing now.

She had tried to back out of this situation.

Her original plan had been a simple one: if Michael had drunk the wine, then it would have been a sign that she shouldn't do what she was thinking about doing.

She hadn't expected him to not only decline the wine, but to actually suggest that she take it over to Gabe. He didn't seem to be just talking about taking over a bottle of wine, either.

So, she found herself holding the wine, walking across the lawn in the dusky night. Walking right to Gabe's house, her stomach churning.

She had thought about going through with it all evening long. Gabe had come home at 6:30, and he was there alone. She had watched his driveway like a hawk, watching for him as she went about far more business in the kitchen than she actually had reason for.

She'd then had a moment of cowardice and lack of resolve. She really shouldn't be leaving a decision like this to what had been "implied" between herself and her husband.

She'd called Michael. She was ready for him, almost hoping for him, to say something that would talk her out of what she had decided to do.

But he didn't answer the phone. He hadn't returned her two messages.

She had texted him, but it had been a half-hearted, vague attempt at communication.

[Me]: *I guess you're busy. I just wanted to chat before bed.
Call me if you get this in time.*

Very half-hearted. Hardly a cry for help, or a plea to make him try and stop her from doing what she was about to do. "In time," could have meant anything, and she hadn't explained it, even to herself.

The grass was damp with condensation. The evening had cooled, and the skimpy black dress she was wearing was far too cold for her, but it was too late to turn back without looking foolish if Gabe saw her crossing the lawn.

She shivered and continued on her way, reciting in her mind what she would say when Gabe opened the door.

By the time she reached the foot of his porch, he had already spotted her. In fact, he was walking toward the sliding door with an assured and confident walk, as if they had decided to meet here at this time all along. She gave him a little wave, her hands low at her hip.

She had decided on a black dress that she never wore. She had fished it out of her closet and had been quite happy that it still fit. It was a wraparound that tied loosely at the waist, so it clung to her slender figure and she had been able to adjust it so there was a dramatic dip at her breasts.

She had also gone with Brenna to get her hair cut, and the diabolical Brenna had talked her into a new cut. And some highlights, so her hair was almost blonde.

"He'll like that," Brenna had said, a twinkle in her eye. She hadn't been talking about Michael.

Raine's heart dove through her chest as she remembered the encounter. She had told herself it *was* for Michael, that she was only doing it to inject some freshness into their relationship, to take care of her appearance more, to introduce a little excitement.

But the truth was that she had done it for *him*. For Gabe.

Between the sexy dress, and the way she had let it hang loosely about her, and her blonde highlights and new haircut, she looked quite a bit different. She caught sight of herself in the reflection of the glass, and almost didn't recognize her own figure.

She looked hot. Which was, disturbingly, exactly what she wanted.

Gabe slid the door open and looked her up and down. Then, instead of saying anything, he sucked on his lower lip.

She prayed silently that she wouldn't trip walking up the steps, and let out a little puff of relief when she arrived safely on the top layer of the deck. She extended the wine toward him. He had started to lean against the door frame, his eyes on her.

Her hand shook a little. She looked down at it, catching sight of her wedding ring and feeling a pang of guilt. She should go, she should turn back, this was crazy.

Gabe reached for the wine, as though he knew she was faltering, and his hand wrapped around hers, his fingers sliding sensually over the back of her hand.

"Hey," she managed to say. "I got this... I thought... this is for the other day," she finished, her chest as tight as if an elephant were standing on it. "I...um... I mean, Michael isn't home so I just thought -"

"You do something to your hair?" Gabe interrupted.

She felt her insides melting. "Uh.. yeah, just highlights."

The conversation was normal enough. She almost started to relax, as Gabe took a step backward and let her in. She stepped into the cool air, shivered slightly, stepped out of her shoes, and was preparing to sit down when he said:

"You do that for me?"

The skin on her back rippled with a cold chill. She turned abruptly, and began to blabber. "I, well, I... my hair? What?"

He was smiling. He took a step toward her, silencing her with his calm, steady stare. He took her by the elbows, and his hands slid up, along her triceps, to her shoulders, then back again. "You did it for me," he said, his eyes looking at her hair. "I have a thing for blondes."

Raine could not concentrate on what he was saying, though, because his hand was traveling down the center of her torso, igniting her body as it traveled.

And then he cupped her between the legs, pulling her toward him until their skin was touching. His body was warm, almost hot, and firm everywhere. She had a sudden attack of fear: there was something savage and animal about Gabe, and now that he was this close to her, and had his hand on her pussy, she realized she couldn't really stop any of this.

Still, she could make an effort. She should, right?

"I should... I should maybe... go," she said. Her voice was barely above a whisper. As she spoke, Gabe tugged gently upward, making it hard for her to squirm or move at all without his fingers rolling right over her clit and making her shudder. "Michael's not home, though, is he?" he said. "So you could just stay."

"I..."

She didn't have any idea what she had meant to say.

Gabe's fingers were pushing the dress open at the legs, seeking out her pussy. He held her frozen in place with his eyes, and she felt the thrill of his particular kind of domination, even before he jerked on her panties so that his fingers could get to her wet flesh.

When he encountered her shaved lips, she could see that he recognized what she had done – and that she'd done it since he'd touched her there at the party. And so of course he knew, just as well as she did, that this had really been her intention all along.

Gabe slipped a finger into her folds and it wobbled in her dripping flesh before pressing on her clit and making her muscles tense. Gabe smiled.

He leaned back a little, still keeping her frozen in his gaze. It took her a moment to realize that he was sliding his phone from the table, and at the same time pulling his finger from between her lips. He brought it to her mouth as his other hand brought the phone up, and she didn't need to be told what he wanted: she opened her mouth and let him put his finger, tangy with her own juices, between her lips. She sucked her juices from his black flesh as he took the picture.

"What's Michael's number?" he asked her.

The spell he had cast on her threatened to break. She could feel herself falling, any minute she would break through a glass floor of some kind. "Wait, what?" she said. She looked at the phone, realizing what his plan was, imagining the picture, imagining how Michael would feel when he saw it.

"Trust me," Gabe said. "He'll want this." He looked over the edge of the phone at her. "Or was he mad when you told him about the last time I got my fingers inside of you?"

Raine was glad that he didn't seem to want her to actually answer, because he rubbed his thumb over her lower lip and gave her a hard look that indicated that he didn't want to do much more talking.

She recited the numbers in a partial whisper. Her chest was alive with what felt like flying shards of ice as Gabe typed the number in, and then his fingers swept over the screen.

Sending it. Sending the picture of her lips closed around Gabe's dark finger. From his phone. No message.

It excited her. Whatever she wanted to tell herself about how she felt, the truth was seeping into her panties. Thinking about Michael opening the photo and staring at it excited her almost as much as the pulse of Gabe's cock against her thigh.

He had his fingers on the strings of the wrap. She could feel him tugging on it.

“We'll take this first part nice and slow. Maybe Michael will have time to get here.”

Raine felt silly as she said, aloud, what she was thinking: “But it's two hours...” she let her voice trail off.

“I'm not gonna be done with you in two hours,” he growled.

CHAPTER 15

The universe was already conspiring to get him back to Cleveland, back to his wife, long before he got the text.

His final client had been called away from their intended cocktail and possible strip club evening in a hurry, and that left Michael alone at the Red Light, a trendy bar that had an odd, campy vibe in the early evening, which is when he found himself there.

He sat in a low-lying lounge chair, weighing his options. There were soon to be all kinds of very young, very beautiful girls filling up the bar with their open mouths and laughter, long legs and flat, bared stomachs.

His mind was on none of that at all. His thoughts were on his own wife, and their neighbor, and the trap he and Gabe had set for her.

Or had it worked like that at all? He's only had one whiskey, almost as if he'd foreseen the whole evening and knew he would soon be driving home, but the one drink had turned his thoughts dark.

What if Gabe and Raine were playing *him*?

Did it really matter if they were, if he got what he wanted in the end?

How much of a cuck was he if he *wanted* to see his wife fucked by a black man?

He looked at his phone when Raine called for the second time. He was paralyzed to stop the events that had been set in motion. It would have been easy enough to answer the phone, to tell Raine to come here to Columbus. To ask her not to fuck the neighbor.

But he let the call go to voicemail.

He waited a few moments, deliberating having another drink, before he listened to the messages from his wife.

They were bland, and said nothing about her intentions or her mood:

"Hi, honey, just...um... calling to chat. If you had a moment in between. But, I guess you're pretty busy, so... no need to call back, if it's late. There's no... I'm not calling for any reason."

She didn't really want him to call back, did she?

And then her text, sent at the strange hour of 7:00:

[Raine]: *I guess you're busy. I just wanted to chat before bed.
Call me if you get this in time.*

He hadn't replied. He had stared at the text on the screen of his phone, "*in time*," and the shape of the letters had burned into his retina. Then he had slowly risen from his chair at Red Light, tucked his phone into his jacket, and walked to his car.

His suitcase was still back at the hotel. He had not unpacked it, almost as though he had known all along how this evening would play out. Almost as though this was *his* plan, and not just an alignment of events and luck, or the conspiracy of his wife and neighbor.

He left Columbus behind, and he drove toward Cleveland without thinking. He was only driving, toward whatever was there.

And that's when *the* text arrived.

He opened it while driving, holding it up against the dashboard so he could keep his eyes on the road.

He was momentarily unable to process what he was looking at.

The number was unknown.

The photo was sexually explicit: it swam before him, incomprehensible. Black skin, white skin, lips, flesh between them.

The woman was blonde, the finger (which he mistook, at first glance, for a small black cock) was dark and thick.

And then it hit him, all at once.

The doll-shaped mouth. The tiny nose. The unknown number with a Cleveland area code. The black finger.

He screeched to a halt on the shoulder of the highway and stared at the picture, his heart beating faster with each passing moment.

No message.

Just the picture.

His wife – who had evidently dyed and restyled her hair – with her lips around Gabe Knight's finger.

He sat on the side of the road for a few moments to calm himself down before driving again. His excitement was overtaking, making him jittery, and he didn't want to crash his car at this, the moment he had been secretly dreading and anticipating ever since the neighbor had walked into their life.

He was about an hour away from Cleveland.

Where were *they*?

He had a chilling thought: what if they had somehow gone back to Columbus and he was going the wrong way?

His phone dinged again, and he gripped the wheel as he pulled over on the shoulder again. It was almost 8:00, and the sky was turning dark blue. He turned on his hazards and made a mental note of what an idiot he was parking like a sitting duck on the side of the highway, waiting to be smashed to bits as he -

His heart felt like it physically stopped in his chest when he opened the attachment from the same number. All thoughts flew out of his head, except for that he was glad he had pulled over the car.

The image burned into his eye as he stared and stared, trying to make sense of what he was seeing, not quite believing it was true.

The last photo had been only of Raine's mouth and nose. Slightly out of focus, in dim light, and so it had been easy enough to feel was not quite real.

This photo had been taken with the flash, which threw a stark reality on the scene.

It left no doubt that the woman in the photo – blonde hair or no - was his wife.

Her blue eyes were wide and looking directly into the camera. Her right eye looked as though it was about to spill over, leaking, as it always did, before her left. The eyes, so unmistakably hers, hovered over her nose, her nostrils flared as she struggled to manage breathing.

Because her doll-like lips were stretched to a thin pink line, around a massive column of black cock. About six inches of cock remained for her to swallow. A muscled forearm hung over the top of the picture, a hand reaching out to grab the back of her head and pull it toward the remaining tower of meat, feeding it to her. She was looking right into the camera, right into Michael's eyes.

With her mouth totally crammed full of Gabe's huge cock.

Michael's cock throbbed painfully.

He looked at his notifications bar, his fingers pressing against the screen of the phone, his eyes burning. "Come on," he whispered. "Come on,

come on.” He wasn’t even sure what he was willing the phone, or Gabe, or his wife to do. Send another photo? Tell him it was a joke?

He wanted to drive but he felt like he couldn’t, like he would just be pulling off the road in five minutes anyway. He wanted to take his cock out and jerk off, but he had a feeling he would end up embarrassingly arrested for indecency.

There was little he could do but clutch the phone, stare at his wife’s filthy, cheating mouth, and say, “Come on, come on,” over and over in the hopes that something... anything.... would change.

Another ding.

“Oh God,” he said, as the picture materialized before his eyes. For a moment the image swam in front of him, meaningless, as though it was an impressionist painting and he needed to back away from it.

But that was probably just his blood pressure, because soon it was crystal-clear:

Raine’s lips, pressed against a chocolate wall of flesh. The ripples of his muscles led like a road to the line of her mouth. A smattering of tight, well-trimmed black hair curled up at her lips.

Her eyes were open. A line of gray-black mascara made a rivulet on her right cheek. She looked like she was gagging, and probably was, with all those many, many inches of cock filling her mouth and throat.

Another ding.

His hands shook as he opened the newest photo.

Raine was looking up at the camera again. Her mouth was open, no cock inside of it. The length of black meat was poised above her lips, fat and swollen, held in the grip of Gabe’s fingers.

Michael sucked in his breath.

Raine’s lips were puffy, her eyes watery and red. Her hands were on her knees, like an obedient porn store about to accept a cum shot.

And that’s when he saw it.

Smear on her cheek: a rope of transparent white cum, glistening in the flash of the camera.

And then...

Then...

In the back of her throat, pearly and white, another glob of it.

Gabe’s seed, nestled in the back of his wife’s throat.

And her mouth still open for more.

*

The subsequent moments, and minutes, and almost hour, were like a blur. Like a montage in a movie about a crazy person: scenes layered on each other but none of them making much sense, all of them out of order.

He drove home, essentially in a fugue state. He was in his driveway without remembering passing everything he needed to pass to get there. The gas tank was almost completely empty. He couldn't remember exiting the highway, or navigating the streets to his home.

He could only remember his wife's dirty, cum-stained mouth.

He peered at the house. Lights were on upstairs. Was that where they were? Fucking in their bedroom? Was Gabe spurting his ropes of cum all over his now-blonde wife's face next to the bed that they shared?

He didn't charge in, though. He opened the door gingerly, quietly, and listened for the sounds of them.

Maybe it was over, and they were sleeping. Maybe Gabe had gone home and left his defiled wife in bed, cum sticking to her lips and cheeks, for him to enjoy the sloppy seconds.

But they were not there: he crept up the stairs and knew before he opened the door that there was no one behind it.

He walked to the bathroom, where the large window had a good view of the expansive lawns, of the windows of the rental property, of the lights on in Gabe's house, and the movement inside the house, the drapes not even drawn. Shadows changed the shape of the light as someone – was it them? - moved within the home.

He sat down on the tiled bench of the tub.

Should he go over there?

Maybe Raine was coming back soon. Maybe it was over and he had missed it, but she would come home and find him there, and he would bend her over the counter and fuck his cum into her pussy. Her cheating pussy, or her dirty whore mouth.

He jumped when his phone cheerily notified him of another message. Another photo.

His hands shook so much that he dropped the phone with a clatter into the dry tub.

This photo, too, had a quality about it that made it seem unreal, and like it wasn't his wife. It took him a few moments to realize why, to accept that it was, in fact her, in spite of what he was seeing.

She had shaved her pussy, so the feathery brown that she kept trimmed mostly for swimming weather and often abandoned to its natural state in the winter, was gone. This is why he almost didn't recognize the picture for what it was: a slightly reddened pussy, wrapped around a thick, black column of cock.

Just that. Nothing more.

But it was definitely his wife's pussy, shaved or not. He recognized the curve of her pubic bone, the flattened oval shape of her belly-button. The small mole that rolled over her hip bone as she moved, especially when, as she was now, she lay on her back and spread her legs.

His chest was so tight he wondered for a moment if he was having a heart attack.

And then, before he knew it, he was walking across the lawn. The night was cool. Somehow dew had formed on the grass. His feet were getting wet.

He had left his phone behind.

He had no plan, only a tunnel-vision idea, leading him straight to Gabe's house, to the light spilling onto the porch, to where he knew his wife was acting like a little slut.

At the porch, he stopped dead in his tracks and stared into the house. Until that moment, he had been acting on auto-pilot, his thoughts never making it to a real layer of consciousness. They had driven him forward, toward Gabe and his cheating wife, but he had not let them rise to a place where he could *think*.

Now, faced with a choice about what to do and how to act, he forced himself to consider his options. His wife was inside this house (possibly), fucking another man.

A man with whom he had an arrangement, of sorts.

He had driven Raine to this, and he knew it, so he also knew that he had no right to feel the jealous burn inside of his chest. No right to be angry,

as he was, even if that anger was only one sliver among so many other emotions. He had no right to feel sick to his stomach. He had no right to be so turned on that he couldn't think straight.

He was shaking when he walked toward the sliding door. Somehow, he knew it wouldn't be locked.

Once the door slid open, the warm air inside the house caressed his face. There was a faint odor of alcohol, and layered beneath it there were the scents of sex: a man's body odor; Raine's shampoo; sweat; sweet and tangy pussy; the acrid, brackish scent of fresh cum.

Music was on somewhere, low and unidentifiable.

He closed the door behind him and the sounds made their way to his ears: the light music, the shifting of bodies, the animal panting, and then, stabbing him right through his chest: the slap of skin on skin.

He heard the low rumble of Gabe's voice, coming from the hallway. At the party, Michael had never gone into that part of the house.

He crept toward Gabe's voice. He was twisted up inside: fear was one emotion that grabbed him. After all, what was Gabe going to do if he snuck up on them and was caught?

He didn't really want to interrupt what was going on, he realized, as he moved ever-so-slowly into the dim hallway. At the end of the corridor, a low golden light splashed out of an open door, and dark shadows raced through it as the occupants of the room moved around in front of it.

The occupants of the room. His wife, and Gabe. Who were fucking.

The scents of sex became stronger as he walked down the corridor. After all, they had been at it for a long time now.

The thought of it sent another stab of delicious pain through his torso. Such a long time, fucking and fucking, in every hole, in every way. And still at it.

"He's gonna like this. Trust me."

Gabe's voice was clear now. Low, a rumbling baritone, but clear enough. Michael was about five feet from the door. He could hear Raine's breath, raspy and labored. The shadows shifted.

Raine squealed. "Ooooh," she said.

"Hold still. You can do it," he heard Gabe say.

"I can't," Raine said. "I've never done it before... oh! It's too big... I don't think..."

Her voice trailed off.

Michael quickened his pace, coming to the edge of the door frame. He wondered for a moment if he should interfere, help Raine out of the situation that she “couldn’t” get through.

But he found himself, instead, sinking to his knees, desperate to see what it was, desperate for her to keep going.

There was a wall of mirrored doors on the closet along the side of the room he could see from the door frame. Raine had wanted them removed, claiming they were tacky, but they had run out of money for the renovation and so the mirrored doors had remained.

And boy, was Michael grateful that they had.

He had, from where he sat on the floor on his knees, a perfect view of the bedroom reflected in the mirrors. Again, he had the sensation of not being really there, or being asleep, as he looked at the fantastical scene in front of him. But the sound, the pain of the wood floor beneath his knees, the scent of Raine’s skin and Gabe’s sweat, told him the truth: he was really seeing what he was seeing.

Raine was on the bed, on all fours, her bottom toward Gabe. The curves of the black man’s muscles shone in the dim light, steely ebony in sharp contrast to Raine’s soft, petite, alabaster form.

Gabe’s cock was engorged, pointing straight in front of him. He was supporting the meaty column with one hand, his other hand cupping one of Raine’s buttocks, pulling it slightly to the side. He was moving it between the valley of her ass, and it took Michael a moment to realize what he was witnessing.

Raine, after all, had already let him fuck her pussy.

Almost an hour ago.

“Just relax,” Gabe said.

Raine turned back to look at him. “I don’t know...” she said.

Gabe let his heavy cock drop. It slid along Raine’s inner thigh. Gabe placed his other hand on Raine’s opposite ass-cheek and pushed the small rounds of her ass apart.

Michael’s jaw dropped with his plummeting stomach as Gabe lowered his face to Raine’s ass, and began to lick her asshole in loud, sloppy slurps.

Raine shifted uncomfortably, and her face looked shocked, but Michael could see that she slowly began to enjoy the man playing with her ass.

Michael strained to see the details of what he was doing, but could not. He could only imagine where his tongue was going between the valleys of his wife's firm ass, and judge by the excited squeals that Raine was emitting.

Gabe played with her ass a little longer, then rose back up to his knees. He leaned forward and grabbed Raine's hair and pulled her toward him.

He kissed Michael's wife, biting into her lips, enclosing them in the huge, plum-colored lips of his mouth. The kiss was sloppy and filthy, the wet sounds of it assailing Michael's ears. Their tongues appeared as flashes of wet pink and red, darting in and out of their smooth black and white skin.

Gabe released her and pushed her back into position on the bed. He was handling her much less gently now. And she seemed to already have formed a habit of submission to him. She let her head hang, and she repeated weakly that she didn't know if she should... but she did nothing to move away from Gabe's approaching cock.

He drew his cock from her pussy, which was sloshing wet, to her ass. Raine squirmed and mewled, but remained as she was, ready for him.

"Open up for me. You can do it, baby. Just relax and let it slide right in," he told her.

Raine made an incomprehensible noise as Gabe pushed his hips forward, holding his cock in one hand, and pressed against Raine's tight hole.

"Oh!" Raine said. Her hand flew back toward her ass, and Gabe pushed it away. For a moment, his huge cock almost bent against the pressure of her closed-up ass, and Raine made another noise. "Just relax and open up," he said. "You can do it."

And then, suddenly, his cock was sinking into Michael's wife. Right into her ass.

"Ooohhhhh," Raine exclaimed. "Oh!" She lifted her head, and tried to raise her hand back to her ass again, but Gabe pushed it away a second time and grabbed her by the hips. He thrust deep into her with one hard push, his huge balls swinging low and then slapping her against her wet pussy.

Raine was staring straight ahead, and silent, with her mouth open and her hands balled into the slippery brown fabric of the bed cover. Gabe slowly drew his cock back, and then slowly sank into her again. He repeated this, and Raine mewled.

“There we go,” Gabe said. “That’s just how I knew it would be. Girls like you like it in the ass.”

It *did* seem that Raine – who would never have done anything like this with Michael – in fact liked it very much in the ass. It was almost impossible to believe that she could open that big for Gabe’s enormous cock, let alone enjoy herself, but she was pushing her hips back against him to get him deeper inside.

“Hold on,” Gabe said. He reached down beside his calf and picked something up from the bed. When he lifted it, Michael knew what it was: a phone. Gabe pointed it at his cock sliding in and out of Raine’s ass, and took a picture. Then he took another after he slid in to the hilt.

He stopped with his cock deep inside of her, and tossed the phone to the side. Raine squirmed, impaled on his cock. He slipped his hand around her hip, and between her legs.

Michael could hear her pussy sloshing as Gabe’s fingers dipped into the folds of her pussy. Raine tried to buck against him, and he reached forward with his free hand grabbed her hair, pulling her back toward him, resting onto his heels with Raine plastered against his back.

“Now hold on, darlin’” he said. “Take it easy. I’ve already fucked you three times, and even though your ass feels good, you’re in for a long fuck in the ass.”

Michael’s cock pulsed painfully.

Gabe played with Raine’s pussy, his cock still deep in her ass. He held her on his lap with one hand on her shoulder, while his fingers slowly explored her drenched cunt.

Raine moaned, tortured by his slowness. She tried to bounce on his cock but he kept her pressed firmly to his thighs. She moved her ass in a circle, grinding against him.

“Please,” she said. “I want to...”

Gabe’s hand stopped moving between her legs. “I’ll tell you what you want,” he growled. “Now be good, and hold still while I make you come.”

Then I'm going to fuck your ass raw. Don't worry. You'll get what's coming to you."

Raine moaned. Michael flinched, wondering if his wife was really into this humiliating, barbaric treatment as much as she seemed to be. But then he remembered how hot their encounters had been since Gabe had been in their lives, and he realized this was *exactly* what she wanted.

If he needed further proof, she began panting and moaning on Gabe's lap as he started to rub her pussy furiously. His fingers sloshed in her juices, and her voice rose a few octaves in a strangled scream as he drove her to orgasm.

When she came, he pushed her with both hands by the shoulders, so that she could not bounce on his cock. He sucked his lower lip, leaning back, thrusting upward into the depths of her ass. "Oh, man," he hissed. "That's what I like. Squeeze that cock, baby, oh yeah, just like that. Your ass feels so good. There we go."

Raine squealed away as she came, and her pussy sloshed. Michael couldn't see, but he could hear, that she was dripping down to Gabe's fat balls, right to her ravaged hole. Now she would be all lubed up when he "fucked her ass raw."

Michael's own cock was dripping precum into his suit. He wanted to touch himself but he still feared being caught, and he was almost paralyzed as he watched his wife come like a slut on the neighbor's cock.

Gabe let her orgasm die down, her ass undoubtedly squeezing him, pulsing around his dick inside of her hot, tight ass.

Michael would fuck her there, too. Right after he got her home. Right after he filled her mouth, and her pussy, with his own cock to get the taste of Gabe's cum from inside of them.

Gabe pushed Raine forward onto the bed when she was done, and she fell onto her chest, clearly exhausted.

It made no difference to Gabe, who manhandled her by grasping her hips and pushing her legs together between his thick thighs. Raine's feet twisted as he pulled his cock slowly back, and then shoved himself deep inside of her. "Mmm," he growled.

He started to fuck Michael's wife like a rag doll. As he pounded into her, Raine turned her head and stared blankly at the mirror, either too exhausted or too submissive to respond. Her eyes were glassy and her lips

were swollen, her cheeks streaked with dried cum. She let Gabe slide her body over the covers, bunching them beneath her, as he rammed into her with sharp wet slaps.

This went on for what seemed like a very long time. Somewhere in the middle of it, Raine's mouth fell open, and she started to gasp. Though it seemed incredible, she seemed to be getting turned on again. She clutched the covers, balling them into her fist.

Gabe had shoved her forward with his thrusts and her head slid into the headboard. Raine put a hand up to stop herself from banging into it, but it still crashed against the wall as Gabe pounded into her even harder.

Finally, when it seemed that his wife would be split in two by Gabe's cock, Gabe arched his back slightly, looked up at the ceiling, and all the muscles of his body tensed. He let out a roar – it really couldn't be called anything else – as he dumped his seed into Raine's ass.

He pushed his hips forward and jerked her back against him.

Raine let out a howl of disappointment and her feet kicked behind her as she tried to push against him and grind out yet another orgasm. Gabe let out a chuckle and held her in place. "Man, you're a horny little slut," he said.

Raine mewled. "Please," she panted. "I'm so close."

Gabe held her in place and watched her, but he did not satisfy her craving. He lifted his hand and gave her a swat on the ass, leaving a red mark on her skin. "Let me get this one last thing for your husband. Then I'll let you come."

His cock flopped out of her ass, still semi-hard, soaked with creamy cum. Raine made a noise of disappointment.

Gabe lined up the phone with Raine's ass. "Put your hands up there," Gabe growled. "Hold open that filthy little asshole for me."

Michael shuddered as he took the picture.

Raine moved her ass again. "I want.. I want..."

"What do you want, baby-doll? You want my cock back in your ass? I'm afraid I can't help you there. You're wearing me out."

While he said this, he fanned his fingers, and dipped two of them into Raine's ass. The others sloshed in her pussy. He began to finger-fuck her ass and her cunt with his fat hand. The juices of Raine's pussy squelched and sloshed, and she moaned, face-down, into the sheets of the bed and the

bunched-up covers, until at last, her thighs hardening into muscled ropes and her ass sloshing loudly, she screamed, and came again.

Gabe pushed his fingers deep inside of her, picked his phone up one last time, and took another picture.

Raine collapsed on the bed when he pulled his fingers out of her.

“Phew!” Gabe said. He backed up until he could stand at the end of the bed. “You’re a real live one.”

He reached for a robe. Michael was still on his knees, transfixed, as though the scene in front of him were porn on a computer screen and not real people. Suddenly, he realized that Gabe was putting on the robe, moving... coming toward the hallway!

He rose, shakily, to his feet.

“I gotta go get something to drink. What you want, baby-doll?” Gabe was saying.

Michael backed up. The last thing he saw in the mirror was Gabe sitting down on the edge of the bed, pushing Raine’s hair from her face.

When he could see no more, he turned, and with his heart pounding, he moved toward the door, opened it, and stepped outside. He was down the steps and onto the lawn when he realized that he hadn’t closed the door behind him. He gave a glance backward, saw only the light of the kitchen, decided he didn’t care, and walked – much more slowly – to his home, to wait for his wife.

*

Raine only dozed, and when she was sure that Gabe had fallen asleep – on his back, a soft snore coming from his nose – she sat up.

She looked at herself in the mirror. She hardly recognized the woman who looked back at her: her light-colored hair was a mess, her mascara running, her face encrusted with cum. Her pussy throbbed and her ass felt stretched and wet.

A shiver traveled down her spine as she remembered every filthy act she had performed with Gabe. The shiver turned to a chill when she remembered that Gabe had taken a picture of each and every thing she had done, and sent them to Michael.

Michael.

He had wanted this. Gabe seemed sure of it.

Michael had not sent a frantic message to her, or called her, or put a stop to any of this as he received photo after photo.

Still. Her heart was spinning wildly out of control with fear and anxiety as she gathered up her things from around Gabe's house, and crept out into the night. Thousands of "what-ifs" invaded her mind: what if Gabe had never sent the photos at all? What if Michael had only been role-playing, acting out a fantasy when they had discussed this possibility? What if Michael could read her mind somehow, and know that she had done what she had done for herself, as much as for him? What if he could sense that the badness, the wrongness of what she had done had been just as enticing to her as anything else?

It was true that she loved Michael, she realized, as her heart plummeted with the thought that he might not forgive her. How could she make him understand that, if he took things the wrong way? What would she do if he *didn't* understand, or he didn't forgive her? And why would she not have thought of all of this before?

Her ass was sore, and the ache rolled through her body as she walked. It was a pleasant feeling, even though it ached. She had never had anal sex before, and she had liked it. Gabe's cum, warm from her body, was still leaking down her thighs. She had her underwear clutched in her hand; the juices dripped down her legs unimpeded.

God, she was such a slut. She couldn't believe what she had done.

What would Michael actually do, now that she had done this terrible thing?

Her heart fell through her chest again and her eyes welled up with involuntary tears.

She stopped cold at the back door of their house. The kitchen light over the stove cast a glow on the floor in the dining room, and beyond the shiny wood floor she could see the light in the living room.

She wiped her eye, which had shed a single tear. Had she left the living room light on?

Her lips trembled as she approached the door, clutching her panties in one hand, feeling like a shameful whore. Her heart pounded in her chest as she turned the doorknob.

She jumped, and yelled, when she opened the door and saw Michael standing in the kitchen. The scream was involuntary, louder than it needed to be. Her cheeks flushed.

“Wha..?” she said.

Her eyes fell on the phone in his hand. The filthiness of her acts with Gabe flooded her mind.

Michael’s face was unreadable. He was staring at her with an intensity she had never seen before, but she could not pick apart if he was angry, jealous, passionate, or dumbfounded.

She herself could find no words, so she stood where she was, pushing the door closed behind herself, squeezing the panties in her hand as her heart seemed to expand with every beat until her chest was so full it would explode.

“I came home early,” Michael finally said.

“I did it,” was all she could get out of her mouth. She looked at the phone again. “But I guess you know... that.”

There was a long pause. Michael said nothing, and finally she was unable to wait for him to speak.

“Tell me it’s okay,” she said, her voice wavering. “I’ll tell you all -”

Michael was crossing the kitchen. He put his fingers to her lips, and pulled her lower lip down as his fingers moved to her chin. She was struck silent for a moment, unsure of what he was going to do. She realized what was going on: he was sliding the dress from her shoulders, his fingers exploring her body as though she were an object that had been returned to him and he was assuring himself it was all in one piece.

It was as if the expression on his face deciphered itself suddenly. The look he was giving her was one of passion and desire. Her heart leaped as she realized it; he was going to forgive her, and reclaim her, and there was a real possibility that he would forgive or even condone what she had done.

With this realization came a tantalizing idea, one that aroused her as much as it took her by surprise: she wanted to return to him, to obtain his forgiveness, to confirm his love for her. Her feelings of confusion, her mixed emotions and misunderstandings coalesced into a clear understanding, like someone had cast a light on everything in a single moment: this was at the heart of what they had done, together.

Michael's hands were pulling the dress away from her body, moving over her nipples. They were hard, and ached from where Gabe had pinched them as he had pulled her onto his lap and thrust his cock deep inside of her.

Michael's hands played with her breasts, gently massaging their tender tips, and then traveled down, over her navel, where they seemed to linger on the rough patches where Gabe's cum had dried on her stomach after dripping from her chin. When she had sucked his cock he had held her head and squirted one shot in the back of her throat, and then tipped her head back as the second and third squirts had sprayed across her lips and cheek, and then her chin, dripping onto her skin as she obeyed Gabe's wish to see the cum she was going to swallow.

Michael's fingers continued down, to the bareness of her pussy. She wondered what he thought of the fact that she had shaved for Gabe. How much intention did it reveal, on her part? And what would he think of that?

He smiled as his fingers brushed over her bare lips. "I like this," he told her, and he bit softly into her lower lip. "It's very, very naughty."

She gasped as he slipped a finger between her folds. She knew they were soaked, dripping with Gabe's cum, and Michael's hands would encounter all the evidence of her bad behavior first-hand. Her whole body shook as he touched her swollen, aching clit. She could hardly endure the sensation, she had been so thoroughly fucked by Gabe.

Michael looked at her questioningly.

"I'm so sore," she said, to explain.

"That's too bad," Michael said. It was hard to tell if he meant that he genuinely felt sorry for her, or if he meant that it wasn't his problem. Whatever it was, she could see that there was to be no stopping him: he was going to reclaim her, and there was nothing to be done about it but to endure the sweet, intense pain of it.

He pushed her back against the door, and she almost stumbled as her dress slipped over her waist and got caught by her knees. Michael pulled at it, and the fabric ripped before slouching down at her calves. She shimmied one leg out of it so that Michael could push her thigh up and finger her.

Every pulse of his fingers against her clit sent a jolt through her body. She was so over-stimulated from what she had done that, even as it made her hungry for more, she would have gladly asked for release from him. She had once masturbated with the pulse setting of the shower head and held it

to her clit past when she had climaxed: this was just as painfully, beautifully intense and unbearable. But she had done that for only moments. Michael seemed determined to keep at it for a very long time.

She whimpered as he pinched her between his fingers. "I can't take any more," she crowed, but she knew this would only drive him wilder.

"I'll decide what you can take, you dirty, unfaithful little whore."

A wave of pleasure surged through her.

Michael's fingers plunged into her pussy. They slid into the stretched folds of her body like a knife in butter. She could feel three, maybe even four of them exploring her insides. He clawed against her g-spot, and flexed his fingers outward, stretching her until she could feel the sting of her limits. Her pussy sloshed, the sound of her infidelity loud and humiliating.

Michael pushed into her deep, and she mewled against his ear.

"Do you want it deeper?" he growled. "Or can you even feel it after Gabe's big cock stretched you out like a dirty little whore?"

He pushed her hand up above her, and saw the panties, still clutched in her fist. She opened her hand to drop them, and he caught them in his own and smiled.

He thrust his hand deep inside of her and clawed forward against the root of her clit one more time, then pulled his hand from inside of her and let her whimper at the sudden, crushing disappointment of being emptied yet again, just as her arousal had begun to wind up again.

His fingers were at her mouth, and she knew what he wanted as he ran them along her lower lip. She sucked at his finger-tips, eating her own juices mixed with the bitter taste of Gabe's cum.

Michael pulled on her jaw. "That's a very, very dirty mouth you have," he said.

Her eyes went wide. She *did* have a very dirty mouth, and she had tasted her own ass on Gabe's lips, sucked her cum and his from her fingers and his. But how did Michael know this?

He fed the panties into her mouth, pushing them in beneath her surprised expression.

"I watched you with him," he said. "I watched you let him fuck you in the ass. Did you like that? Did you like that big, black cock in your ass?"

Her eyelids were heavy. She blinked to indicate that she had: if he had seen, he would surely know this. And a new desire surged inside of her, one

she almost couldn't believe herself. She hoped he was headed where she thought he was.

His hands moved faster than her thoughts, though, and he lifted her at the knee on each leg to spread her legs open, pushing her hard against the door. Somehow, in all of the action, he had freed himself from his pants, and she felt the very hard knob of his cock brush over her thighs, against her swollen, throbbing eyelet, and then bury itself in her pussy.

"I'm just going to get my cock nice and wet," he breathed in her ear, "And then I'm going to fuck you in the ass, now that I know you like it so much."

Her legs had begun to tremble: there was no hiding from him that she was wild with desire, nearing another climax. That, in fact, she was a filthy-minded slut. She moaned into her panties and closed her eyes. The orgasm that was overtaking her was going to be so intense she did not know how she would withstand it. She was losing control of herself and her body.

Michael dropped her legs suddenly, and they slipped down to the ground. He turned her around and pushed her sideways to the counter.

She felt his thumbs pulling her ass-cheeks apart. For a moment he did nothing: he seemed to be staring at the gaping hole left by Gabe's abuse. Her face flushed again as she imagined it. He swiped a finger around the sore rim of her ass, and the same, too-intense shudder that had made her gasp when he pinched her clit made her yelp into the panties in her mouth.

Her insides pulsed with craving. She wanted him to fuck her there, she wanted to feel the fullness of his cock inside of her.

He slid into her sore ass the same way he had into her pussy, but his time her body clung to him as tightly as a glove. The fullness made her squirm in delighted, aching, need. He cupped her in front, his fingers pushing against her pussy to pull her back and deep onto his cock as he fucked her, slowly and gently – too slowly, dragging out the agonizing pleasure for much longer than she thought she could take it – until she came.

Her muscles clenched around his cock, and stars clouded her vision, as an orgasm so intense she thought it might choke the life out of her, seized her and rendered her first stiff as a statue and then limp as a rag doll.

Michael pounded at her ass but she was so overcome she would never be able to say how long that went on, until she felt the burst of hot cum,

overflowing, dripping down her thighs: a dirty mixture of all the very, very bad things she had done that night.

*

Raine fell asleep against his chest in the bathtub that night. He had wanted to take her to bed and make love to her, but instead he held her and looked out the window at the dark yard, the sun just lighting up the edges of the horizon visible through the trees. Gabe's house was lit by the same lights that he had left on all night: he was probably asleep, where Raine had left him.

His fingers explored her body, assuring himself that she was really there. He was also tired, but not enough to fall asleep. He enjoyed the feeling of her skin against his in the warm, cleansing water, the silent morning. The new dawn in the east felt, as cheesy as it may have been, like a new dawn on their marriage.

Because, in the end, Raine had come back to *him*. Back to their house, back to their love. As incredible as it seemed, he felt sure that something had been strengthened between them, or that he had tested the strength of their bond, and it had held firm.

She stirred and was half-awake, with wide, dark and empty pupils as he made her stand up so he could get her out of the tub and wrapped in a towel. He found the strength to carry her to their bed. He lowered her onto the sheets and she seemed to be asleep as he tucked a blanket around her and lay down next to her, his own eyelids heavy.

But just as he began to drift off to sleep she murmured:

"I love you."

And for the first time, in a long, long time, the words did not seem like an empty platitude, an exchange for over the phone goodbyes. She meant it.

He kissed her shoulder and let his arm enclose her. "I love you, Raine."

She was a new Raine, and he didn't know where this new and uninhibited person would take them. But he also knew that it didn't matter, because he had her love as well.

END

MORE FROM ARNICA BUTLER

Interracial hotwife books by Arnica:

Interracial Hotwife Bundle

Includes *The Tenant*, *Not Black and White*, and *Grand Slam* for \$5.99

Claudia Changes Tack

Mike is on his friends' luxury sailboat with his stunning blond wife Claudia, hoping for nothing more than to convince Claudia that sailing is enjoyable. It turns out that his friends are swingers, in the Caribbean for more than just the sailing. And it turns out that Claudia has a streak of voyeurism in her. The couple embark on a mild adventure of exploration and sexual reawakening on the warm, beautiful beaches of the Caribbean, and it seems like the ideal vacation.

Grand Slam: An Interracial Hotwife Adventure

Charles keeps a secret desire about his wife Zoe. Her sizzling beauty is typically hidden under scrubs and a hair bun, so his fantasy may never happen. But a wrong turn on a weekend getaway turns out to be the opening pitch of a very naughty game, and Zoe seems determined to knock it out of the park.

The Tenant: A Very Naughty Hotwife Novel

Once upon a time, his exotic and incredibly sexy wife Anna loved to indulge Brian's fantasies...to a point. She teased strangers, and took them to cruel, tantalizing places. But she never went all the way. The game ended when Brian and Anna got married, and that was that.

Or was it?

When the gorgeous, charming, and very black John moves into their basement rental, Brian finds that his sleeping desires have been building up all these years. He doesn't just want Anna to tease. He isn't just toying with the idea. He is obsessed with driving his wife to do things with another man. Lewd things. Obscene things.

When he confesses his desires, is Anna just a little bit too willing to make things just like old times? Is she too easy to push over each new line? Brian can't help but wonder if his own obsessions have gone too far...or if Anna's have.

Not Black And White

When a photographer turns Rick on to the idea of watching his wife with another man, Rick feels an obsessive desire inside of himself catch fire. He can't help arrange for his shy, girl-next-door wife Danielle and the rugged, black photographer to cross paths. He knows that Drake Reyes' erotic photographs are not as abstract as they appear, and that Reyes sleeps with his married models. He knows his wife is not immune to Reyes' charms – no one is. He just can't help but imagine what it would be like to stand in his gallery, looking at Reyes' lurid photos, knowing his own wife is the model, knowing how the photos were taken.

But was it really his idea, or have Drake and Danielle been as manipulative as he has?

Please note, this is the novelized version of the short story Black and White, with significant changes to all scenes depicted in the short story, as well as the point of view. There is, however, some repetition: scenarios which occurred in the short occur in the novel. There are plenty of fresh new adult scenes, however. Please enjoy.

Unlocking Noel: A Reluctant Hotwife Novel

Pretty, bookish Noel is not exactly an adventurer in or out of the bedroom, and Spencer has come to accept that. But things take an unexpected turn one year at an annual ski vacation. When they return the following year, Spencer gets to work on unlocking Noel and her (literally) dark desires.

A romantic hotwife novel with a deliciously corruptible and reluctant heroine.

Lisa Plays Her Part

Lisa and Luke married young because of an unexpected pregnancy, and Lisa never had much experience with other men as a result. But when a dark, handsome, wealthy man she almost slept with (and always wondered about) resurfaces in her life, Lisa is confronted with agonizing desires... and choices. Now that their nest is empty and they don't have the same reasons to stay together, will Lisa and Luke reconnect, or will Lisa choose to make this the final act of their marriage?

Megyn For The Win

In Megyn's view, nothing could be sillier than entering a charity contest to win a "date" with the sexy black celebrity Max Riley, not even to raise money for underprivileged youth. (Un)fortunately for her, her friend entered her in the contest anyway.

When she wins, her husband Peter sees a chance to dip into a fantasy of his. But when this brush with fate turns into a very real, permanent job offer for Megyn – one that puts her in close and frequent contact with the famed black actor - the couple has a lot more to think about than just a winning a "date."

A romantic, interracial hotwife story with a win at the end!

Romantic Hotwife Books By Arnica:

Working On Her Game

Will has landed a lucrative position at a law firm in New Mexico, but the transition to the slow-moving, scorching Southwest has been a strain on his marriage. His wife has surprised him by taking up a new sport to fill her time. But it isn't long before the couple discover that Scarlett's new instructor can give her a lot more than just tennis lessons. Her dark, handsome tennis coach might have just the thing their marriage needs...

Don't forget to check out Game For More, the sequel to Working On Her Game

A Taste For Teasing

Oren knows he's a lucky man with a hot wife: Monica is blonde, stunning, and has a killer body. She was even a cheerleader in the NBA in her university days – and there are even more interesting jobs in her resume than that. But Monica is also a practical, down-to-earth, and happily married woman.

Things take a turn one year when they're vacationing with friends. Oren discovers that he has a taste for thinking about his wife with another man. And Monica has a taste for... well, something. Monica is becoming a hotwife before his eyes: but Oren can't be sure of *who* she's teasing. Is his fantasy coming true, or is it turning sour? Was there more to Monica's past than she ever let on? Is a hotwife really what he wants?

Ela's Performance

Peter's sweet-faced and fiery wife is headed back to school for a degree in violin performance. Unexpectedly, Peter finds himself becoming very paranoid about who Ela is spending so much time with, and what she is

doing at school so very late. It isn't as if he doesn't have his reasons for suspicion. There's the way his own relationship with Ela started, and their own past experiment with an open relationship before they were married. A few other strange things to fuel his jealous fantasies...

And when he discovers someone from Ela's past has resurfaced, he'll take a chance and confront his own desires and obsessions...but will he get what he really wants?

The Houseguest

Sharing and temptation...and sharing temptation. An old buddy returns to Erik's hometown, down on his luck and getting a divorce. By offering to let Ethan stay with them, Erik sees a way to get closer to making his wife-sharing fantasies a reality. To his delight, Natalie seems to be game for something far more adventurous than ever before. But as things heat up, Erik can't help but wonder: Who's seducing whom?

A Conventional Hotwife

Paul Banks was thrilled when a luggage mix-up five years ago opened a window of opportunity for his long-buried desires. Since that time, he and his wife have been playing a little game at their yearly company conventions, and every year his wife ups the ante, going further into his fantasies. But Kathy Banks might be getting just a bit out of control, and things might be going a little too far...

Or not.

The Hotwife Summer

When Ben and Summer have the chance to spend the summer in Italy, their stale marriage starts to heat up in ways Ben could only have dreamed about. Summer is ready to take his hotwife fantasy all the way, and her choice is a sexy, Italian, Michelin star-studded chef. It's too late to put the brakes on what he's set in motion when Ben discovers the humiliating truth about

Summer's choice of man. Summer has a taste for being naughty, and a filthy little plan of her own. Will it be everything he could wish for, or will Ben's cuckold fantasy turn into a nightmare he can't escape?

Body of Research

When ever-suspicious Chris plays private detective on his wife's phone and finds that she uses dozens of dating apps, he worries that his darkest fantasies have come true. And it may not be as delicious as he had imagined.

It turns out that Jen is up to something other than cheating, and the door is open for the two of them to explore the boundaries of their marriage. But in any experiment, the results can be unexpected...

The Hobby Job

Former career professional Laura is going crazy living her stay-at-home-mom life in a small country town. Her husband Conrad has the perfect solution: get a “hobby job.” Laura gets turned on to the idea, and to Conrad's surprise, chooses to wait tables at a run-down restaurant down the street. But she gets a lot more than a hobby job when she meets Nate, a young, hot waiter who has his eyes on her from the start.

Conrad and Laura start on separate journeys, exploring new possibilities in their marriage, and opening up to their hidden desires, fantasies, and needs. Will their journeys merge, or will Laura's “hobby job” make a hobby of their marriage?

The Hotwife Tattoo

When Greg's brother marries his wild, tattooed, ex-girlfriend Renee, he knows things will be a little complicated. But when Renee befriends his wife Sara, she starts to change in almost unbelievable ways. Greg sees that there is something more to Renee's plans than just friendly sister-in-law

bonding. Is Renee's influence all bad, or can Greg get something he has always wanted and never admitted to his wife – maybe even himself?

*Hotwife **Suspense** By Arnica Butler*

Nila's Long Con

It began with a chance encounter with a man from his wife's past. Rich knew Tennile had some skeletons – of a sexual nature – in her closet, but he never dreamed they were going to come back to haunt them both. Before he can blink, the two of them are embroiled in high-stakes intrigue, with Tennile's reputation and career, their marriage, and a lot of money on the line. There seems to be no way out but to play the game, and Tennile's past might be game-winning asset. In the style of *A Well-Laid Trap*, this is a thrilling hotwife ride that will keep you hooked until the end.

A Well-Laid Trap

It all begins when Patrick is convinced he saw his wife with another man at a downtown bar.

He begins to investigate. But the more Patrick uncovers about Jordan's activities, the less he understands.

The biggest problem is, Patrick can't decide how he really feels. On the one hand, his wife seems to be betraying him, and on the other, his sex life has reached a scorching pinnacle he never thought possible.

But he had better hold on to his hat, because when he finds out the truth, things will get much, much hotter than he might have ever imagined...

*Fun **Summer Swinger** Titles:*

Clothing Optional

Sy Price and his wife find themselves in an unexpected situation when their Belize vacation resort turns out to be "Clothing Optional." They're even

more surprised to find out that “Clothing Optional” is code for quite a bit more. They decide to make the best of things and enjoy their vacation. But there are a lot more surprises in store for Sy when Jackie decides to fully embrace the hotel amenities...

A Summer Vacation

Poor Keith. He's been condemned to a campy cruise with his family and friends. Worse yet, he suspects something is going on between his wife and bad-boy Hank, the husband of a family friend his wife has invited along. Keith's in for a very big surprise – and much more naughty, adult fun than he expected on this cruise – when he finds out what's really going on.

Try To Have Some Fun

Helena and Steve's wealthy, sexy, swinger friends have returned to town. Helena has a child- and work-free stretch of summer ahead of her. There's nothing stopping her from spending her days relaxing by their spectacular pool. No reason not to borrow a tiny bikini, or to maybe sunbathe topless. Or skinny-dip at one of their wild parties. One thing, though, will probably lead to another...

Explore darker themes by Arnica Butler:

Well-Constructed Affairs

As a hot female construction engineer, John's wife Adria draws a lot of attention at the job site. Which isn't all bad. But when Adria opens the door for him to tell her about his sexual fantasies, he doesn't realize she has opened the door on her own – very dark – fantasy as well. A fantasy she hasn't shared with anyone until now. The couple are off on an exploration of their desires...but is their marriage well-constructed enough to withstand the forces of their fantasies?

Nikita Gets In Too Deep

When Cole and his wife Nik arrive at their usual vacation spot in dull Cape Breton, they're taken by surprise by the most unlikely of next-door neighbors: ultra-sexy Paige and wealthy, commanding Mitch. And these new neighbors are full of surprises. Cole and Nik embark on new adventures in their marriage, trying new things and pushing boundaries they'd never even discussed. It's invigorating, but Cole can't help but wonder if his transformed wife hasn't gotten herself in too deep...

A Gamble: The Making of A Hotwife

Ryan is just an average guy, coaxing his sweet, beautiful wife Victoria into playing into his hotwife fantasy – even if they're just pretending. But a trip to Vegas with his co-worker Brad and his sexy wife Irena turns Ryan's life upside-down. To help Ryan, Brad makes a proposal that could change everything...but it all centers on Victoria's innocence. How far will Victoria go to save what she holds most dear, now that her virtues, her love for Ryan, their marriage, Ryan's desires, and even their finances all hang in the balance? This is a 52,000-word novel about risk and romance, filled to the brim with the hard, steamy scenes you love. Please enjoy!

A Dark Place: Cuckolded In Lagos

Three people are carving out their fortunes in Africa's largest city, but each of them holds a deeper, darker desire. What is the secret desire of the angelic Charlotte, who finds all men's eyes on her after dark in Lagos? What about Andrew, who keeps a secret hunger so buried perhaps he doesn't admit it even to himself? And what could be darker than Clement Ambode's already shadowy “reliability” as an all-purpose contractor in the underbelly of Lagos?

Charlotte, Andrew, and Clement will find themselves in a very dark place when their worlds collide in this ultra-sexy, novella-length cuckold story.